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CITY OF BERKELEY

BERKELEY CITY COUNCIL SPECIAL MEETING

March 17, 2026

WEBVTT

1
00:00:15.000 --> 00:00:20.239
Boardroom: We have to… We have a…

2
00:00:32.409 --> 00:00:39.050
Boardroom: Okay, hello everyone, good evening! It doesn't feel like evening, does it? It's so hot and sunny out.

3
00:00:39.180 --> 00:00:45.460
Boardroom: Okay, so… I'm just trying to scroll to the top of my agenda.

4
00:00:45.750 --> 00:01:02.279
Boardroom: I'm going to call to order the special… a special meeting of the Berkeley City Council. Today is Tuesday, March 17th, 2026. It's 6.07 p.m, and happy St. Patrick's Day to you all. Clerk, can you please take the roll? Okay, Councilmember Kessnerwani?

5
00:01:03.240 --> 00:01:05.430
Boardroom: Here. Kaplan? Present.

6
00:01:05.640 --> 00:01:06.900
Boardroom: Bartlett?

7
00:01:07.270 --> 00:01:09.040
Boardroom: is currently abnorm.

8
00:01:09.370 --> 00:01:16.749
Boardroom: Traghum? Present. O'Keefe? Here. Blackaby? Here. Unapara? Here. Humbert?

9
00:01:16.750 --> 00:01:17.420
Mark Humbert: Present.

10
00:01:18.060 --> 00:01:24.730

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Boardroom: And Mayor Ishii? Here. Okay, quorum is present. Okay, oh, folks, please, if you're out there.

11
00:01:24.780 --> 00:01:47.830
Boardroom: Please take your conversations outside if you're gonna have a conversation. Thank you. Okay, so we only have one item on the agenda because it is a special meeting this evening, which is the presentation and discussion of community survey results and direction regarding potential ballot measures for the November 3rd, 2026 general municipal election. So I'm going to pass it over to our Deputy City Manager.

12
00:01:47.830 --> 00:01:49.489
Boardroom: David White.

13
00:01:50.330 --> 00:01:51.090
Boardroom: Yep.

14
00:01:51.460 --> 00:01:58.419
Boardroom: Take it away. Thank you. Good evening, Mayor and City Council. Thank you very much for the opportunity to be here this evening.

15
00:01:58.420 --> 00:02:12.090
Boardroom: Just for some logistics, so alongside, I have Carrie Arredondo, our Assistant to the City Manager. Online, we will have, our Public Works Director and Deputy Director, Terrence Davis and Wahid Amiri.

16
00:02:12.090 --> 00:02:24.229
Boardroom: And Scott Ferris, our Director of Parks and Recreation and Waterfront, will be here, very shortly. And also, part of our presentation will be delivered online, from Lake Street Partners David Merman and Emma Scotti.

17
00:02:26.930 --> 00:02:42.630
Boardroom: So, before you, you have the agenda for this evening's presentation. We're gonna set the context and do a little background on how we fund our infrastructure and the gravity of our infrastructure needs, and we did cover some of this territory when we, spoke with you in December.

18
00:02:42.900 --> 00:02:46.780
Boardroom: Then we are going to transition it over to,

19

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00:02:46.780 --> 00:03:09.130
Boardroom: David Merman and the team to provide the results of the community survey, that we launched in early-mid-February of this year. And that community survey was designed, with Council's direction to accomplish two objectives. One, we investigated, the support of Berkeley voters for a $300 million and $200 million general obligation infrastructure bond.

20
00:03:09.220 --> 00:03:23.199
Boardroom: And then also, pursuant to Council's direction in January of this year, we also sought input from Berkeley voters on their support for a potential, general fund sales and use tax measure, to help address the city's general fund deficit.

21
00:03:23.710 --> 00:03:35.840
Boardroom: After we talk about the results of the survey, we're going to talk a little bit about the extensive community engagement effort that is underway, which is being spearheaded and shepherded by our Department of Parks, Recreation, and Waterfront.

22
00:03:35.840 --> 00:03:51.819
Boardroom: our fire department, as well as our public works department. We will not talk about a lot of the results of that community engagement right now, because we are saving that until we can complete the community engagement process, and we come back to you in May with the results of what that is producing for us.

23
00:03:52.220 --> 00:04:01.079
Boardroom: And then we'll talk a little bit about next steps and timelines, about what the way ahead is, and then seeking Council input and direction on recommended actions and next steps.

24
00:04:02.550 --> 00:04:18.139
Boardroom: So let's talk a little about how we fund infrastructure, and clearly the main takeaway from this slide is we do not devote enough resources to address the totality of our infrastructure needs. We are an older community, and our infrastructure is clearly aging.

25
00:04:18.399 --> 00:04:32.760
Boardroom: In terms of looking at the buckets on this slide, from the general fund, we contribute, really revenue or resources to two main areas. About $3 million goes towards our facilities, parks.

26
00:04:32.910 --> 00:04:52.749

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Boardroom: sidewalks, transportation, as well as paying for debt service. And then we, transfer a total of about $9.9 million. There is an inflation adjustment that occurs on that figure, goes towards streets, and that's the results of Council's action a few years ago to really help address, our aging, street network.

27
00:04:53.220 --> 00:05:03.179
Boardroom: We do have one-time resources that come into, our infrastructure, toolbox. That comes from a property transfer tax, as well as, interest income.

28
00:05:03.180 --> 00:05:14.500
Boardroom: But that's volatile, and over the years, we have not been able to transfer all the resources to address capital that we may otherwise like, because the General Fund has needed those resources to sustain operations.

29
00:05:14.650 --> 00:05:23.490
Boardroom: And then we have resources that are restricted by use. Those goes towards our sewer system, our streets, stormwater, street lights, and marina.

30
00:05:24.250 --> 00:05:34.389
Boardroom: And then about why we're here tonight. So, we've been able to, been very lucky to receive voter support, on a number of initiatives over the years to address infrastructure.

31
00:05:34.590 --> 00:05:53.899
Boardroom: And the most recent item that we've been able to bring forward is Measure T1, and we've realized with the sunset of Measure T1, and that all those resources are allocated and going to be fully deployed in the next 1 to 2 years, we realize that there aren't the resources there to address infrastructure in the way that the community would expect, as well as Council.

32
00:05:54.700 --> 00:06:10.729
Boardroom: What we've also been able to do, and this slide does a really good job of highlighting, is that we've been very aggressive in pursuing grant opportunities when they arise. And the one statistic I would point out on this chart is, with $100 million of T1 funding, we've been able to leverage that with $83 million of grants.

33
00:06:10.730 --> 00:06:19.860

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Boardroom: And that work is continuous for us. In fact, just the other day, maybe a week ago, we received notice from the state that we were able to secure a grant.

34
00:06:19.860 --> 00:06:37.630
Boardroom: to help address our mental health facility on MLK. And as… we won't be talking a lot about the project list this evening, but one of the items we addressed in the project list is leveraging that potential grant resource with grant funds, and just want to deliver the message that we will continue to be aggressive in that endeavor and activity.

35
00:06:39.610 --> 00:06:54.869
Boardroom: So this is just another slide to help really encapsulate the depth of the need that we have from an infrastructure perspective. So, we have an unfunded need of about $1.87 billion, and that really is an unbelievable large number when you think about it.

36
00:06:55.000 --> 00:07:03.870
Boardroom: And when you looked at our last 5-year CIP, we believe we calculated about an average spend of about $39 million per year towards our infrastructure.

37
00:07:04.070 --> 00:07:07.850
Boardroom: That is woefully inadequate to address the totality of our need.

38
00:07:08.250 --> 00:07:26.260
Boardroom: So again, understanding the T1 resources are fully deployed, understanding the depth of this need, you know, we took a step back and wanted to think about what would another bond, based on Council's direction to explore this, what could it do, what could it be, and how would we develop a list of projects?

39
00:07:26.600 --> 00:07:44.990
Boardroom: So we took a step back, we gave great consideration to how we've invested resources historically, we thought about community use of our facilities, how to ensure equitable access. We thought about our public safety infrastructure and apparatus, and how to shore that up so we can be responsive to the community.

40
00:07:45.150 --> 00:07:59.440
Boardroom: We thought about projects that could be leveraged with grant funds, we thought about project delivery and project readiness, and all of that allowed us to come together with a preliminary list of projects, and there were a little more than 30 in that preliminary list.

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41
00:07:59.560 --> 00:08:03.070
Boardroom: That really defined itself into these three main buckets.

42
00:08:03.360 --> 00:08:06.790
Boardroom: So the first bucket was community facilities and quality of life.

43
00:08:07.120 --> 00:08:09.429
Boardroom: Which included improvements to parks.

44
00:08:09.450 --> 00:08:18.700
Boardroom: playgrounds, restrooms, aquatic facilities, dog parks, community and cultural centers, and waterfront areas. The second bucket was public safety.

45
00:08:18.700 --> 00:08:35.340
Boardroom: which was really focused and targeted on the modernization of fire stations, and that really, was partially derived and directed from the City Council that adopted a referral in giving us that guidance, as well as resources that are needed to address our 911 dispatch facility.

46
00:08:35.730 --> 00:08:49.439
Boardroom: And then the third bucket was critical infrastructure and accessibility, which was all about seismic upgrades, replacement of public facilities, ADA improvements, and programs such as our 50-50 sidewalk program.

47
00:08:49.540 --> 00:09:10.529
Boardroom: And what was really critical in designing all of these projects is that we also really tried to hold onto a lens of climate resiliency, understanding that we're in a profound period of our time where we need to be prepared for the weather. We're experiencing it today. And so a lot of the projects that were developed were also thought through that lens to ensure that we can be efficient and resilient as we move forward.

48
00:09:12.020 --> 00:09:30.629
Boardroom: So now, I would like to turn it over to David Merman and his team to talk about the results of the survey. And again, as I mentioned before, that survey was really designed to probe a couple of main areas, the infrastructure bond as well as the sales and use tax, that was given direction to us by Council. David, it's all yours.

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49
00:09:31.380 --> 00:09:33.989
David Mermin: Thanks so much. Can you all hear and see me all right?

50
00:09:35.180 --> 00:09:35.920
Boardroom: Yep.

51
00:09:36.150 --> 00:09:43.990
David Mermin: Great. So, glad to be here once again. I am traveling this week, so I couldn't join you in person, although I am,

52
00:09:44.340 --> 00:09:47.649
David Mermin: a Berkeley resident, as well as, having,

53
00:09:48.150 --> 00:09:58.049
David Mermin: done the work on this survey for the City of Berkeley, and as many of you know, we have conducted a series of these community surveys over the years.

54
00:09:58.420 --> 00:10:08.139
David Mermin: tracking, all levels of concern about different issues, awareness and support for the,

55
00:10:08.180 --> 00:10:21.460
David Mermin: Work that the city is doing, and then very specifically, to test potential ballot measures, and in many cases, revenue measures, some of which, of course, were summarized and, of course, placed on the ballot in previous years.

56
00:10:21.560 --> 00:10:36.510
David Mermin: This new survey, I'm not going to go through… there's a longer report, I believe, that's been submitted for everyone to look at, but we are going to just go through the highlights here of the key findings related to this question of an infrastructure bond measure.

57
00:10:37.180 --> 00:10:38.990
David Mermin: That could be placed on the ballot.

58
00:10:39.490 --> 00:10:43.939
David Mermin: During Berkeley, and then, one additional measure that was mentioned in the survey as well.

59

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00:10:44.700 --> 00:10:54.830
David Mermin: So, and I want to also mention my, our senior analyst on the team here, Emma Scotti, who's very much engaged in producing the data you see here and the results.

60
00:10:55.560 --> 00:10:59.690
David Mermin: So, I will put on the screen here…

61
00:10:59.840 --> 00:11:05.720
David Mermin: Our summary slides, and again, this is excerpted from the longer report that any of you have.

62
00:11:06.020 --> 00:11:11.580
David Mermin: And these are findings from a community survey. It was conducted among likely voters in the City of Berkeley.

63
00:11:11.940 --> 00:11:18.539
David Mermin: 500 sample size, which is, gives us a margin of error, plus or minus 4.4%.

64
00:11:18.690 --> 00:11:28.009
David Mermin: so you can look at the numbers with that in mind. And then we're in the field, in the second half of February of this year.

65
00:11:28.470 --> 00:11:37.339
David Mermin: And the… mostly we'll be reporting here the top line results, but we do have lots of crosstabs and other analysis in terms of how different groups of voters in the city

66
00:11:37.900 --> 00:11:40.719
David Mermin: Breakdown on these, on these various questions.

67
00:11:40.950 --> 00:11:48.249
David Mermin: So, this is just a summary of the methodology, all the things I just said about when we fielded, and the margin of error, and so forth.

68
00:11:50.110 --> 00:12:04.389
David Mermin: Just, again, all of these, crosstabs are available in the full report, but, showing you some of the breakdown. Again, this is, of likely voters in the city of Berkeley, people expect to vote and turn out in 2026, November election.

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69
00:12:05.020 --> 00:12:12.319
David Mermin: And so all of those, folks are represented proportionally in the survey relative to their proportion in the

70
00:12:12.730 --> 00:12:14.659
David Mermin: electorate of likely voters.

71
00:12:15.210 --> 00:12:23.720
David Mermin: So here's the overview of the key findings that we learned here, from this survey, that was in the field last month.

72
00:12:23.960 --> 00:12:32.830
David Mermin: We tested a… the infrastructure measure, the GO bond, as it's referred to here, at a couple of different, funding levels.

73
00:12:32.990 --> 00:12:41.809
David Mermin: We also tested a sales tax, ballot measure. They were both, with different results, but both in a good position to pass.

74
00:12:42.100 --> 00:12:52.939
David Mermin: In the sense that the yes vote, the number of voters who say I'd like you to vote yes on that measure, is above the threshold that would be needed for the bond measure, which requires two-thirds to pass.

75
00:12:53.070 --> 00:12:56.999
David Mermin: We're measuring that currently at getting about 70% support.

76
00:12:57.130 --> 00:13:07.240
David Mermin: From Berkeley voters on the initial ballot, first time we ask it, just laying out some ballot language to describe what the bond is, and asking people if they would vote yes or no.

77
00:13:08.730 --> 00:13:19.280
David Mermin: Also note, a key takeaway on the bond is that we tested two different dollar amounts, and we split the sample so people in the survey heard only one

78
00:13:19.280 --> 00:13:30.539
David Mermin: Of those versions all the way through, either 200 or 300 million, and I'll show you the difference in that, but the bottom line is

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there was essentially no difference, and if anything, the larger amount, which includes a

79
00:13:30.650 --> 00:13:42.179
David Mermin: A higher level of tax increase, actually tested slightly better than the smaller amount in terms of having more support from the voters, and we'll show you those numbers.

80
00:13:42.200 --> 00:13:59.049
David Mermin: We also tested a sales tax measure to fund ongoing budget needs, and that was lower in terms of its total yes vote in the survey, but only needing a 50% threshold to pass, it is also above that threshold at 60% yes in our initial test.

81
00:13:59.860 --> 00:14:17.870
David Mermin: We also found, in some broader general questions, that Berkeley voters are fairly satisfied with the city and the direction of things in the city, believing it's going in the right direction, and that the city in general is doing a good or excellent job providing services. There is a wide range of opinions on this, but

82
00:14:18.310 --> 00:14:23.899
David Mermin: Both of those measures have improved, in the sense that the level of satisfaction in the city's a little higher.

83
00:14:24.030 --> 00:14:26.600
David Mermin: Then the last time we measured it, 2 years ago.

84
00:14:27.010 --> 00:14:33.250
David Mermin: And, and a higher proportion also saying that the city's doing a good or excellent job providing services.

85
00:14:33.880 --> 00:14:48.999
David Mermin: And then we also asked about priorities within these areas of infrastructure, funding in particular, and many of the priorities that we tested related to safety, in particular protecting infrastructure from climate change, as mentioned in the

86
00:14:49.000 --> 00:15:03.429
David Mermin: Overall presentation, specifically issues related to emergency services, such as 911 dispatch and fire stations, improving earthquake and seismic protections, and repairing streets and sidewalks in particular for pedestrian safety, all of which

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87
00:15:03.500 --> 00:15:10.710
David Mermin: Got higher levels of priority from the voters out of a list of many, many things that they prioritized, but those were some of the highest.

88
00:15:11.780 --> 00:15:19.319
David Mermin: So from there, let me walk you through some of these numbers that we, got in these total top lines, and then obviously happy to take corrections or

89
00:15:19.500 --> 00:15:22.540
David Mermin: thoughts from the Council or others on this?

90
00:15:23.160 --> 00:15:29.940
David Mermin: So this is the overall direction of the City of Berkeley, and just to note that this is a… it has improved, as I said.

91
00:15:30.060 --> 00:15:38.999
David Mermin: There was a… we've been now measuring this for, 14 years in the City of Berkeley. Some version of this question, is the city going the right or wrong direction?

92
00:15:39.440 --> 00:15:45.350
David Mermin: And we have an uptick over the last, previous measure of this in May of 2024.

93
00:15:45.510 --> 00:16:04.109
David Mermin: when we had 47% of the voters saying the city's going in the right direction, versus 29% saying wrong direction, now it is 56% going in the right direction, and 22% in the wrong direction, and that is a significant increase over that period of 2 years in the positive response on this question.

94
00:16:04.890 --> 00:16:15.030
David Mermin: We also asked, as noted, about the job performance of the city and providing services to its residents. This is a 4-point scale, excellent, good, just, fair, or poor.

95
00:16:15.380 --> 00:16:22.169
David Mermin: And… The proportion saying good or excellent has slightly increased over the last two years. It's now at 56%.

96

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00:16:22.340 --> 00:16:28.869
David Mermin: That is a steady increase from 5 years ago in 2021, when it was at a somewhat lower point at 51.

97
00:16:29.070 --> 00:16:37.400
David Mermin: This has always been a majority, but it is a slightly higher majority this year. 56% good or excellent versus 39% just fair or poor.

98
00:16:39.250 --> 00:17:00.659
David Mermin: That we wanted… before asking about the ballot measures, we also asked about the general priorities in terms of infrastructure for the city, and these are all basically items… we didn't cover every possible thing the city can invest in, but we covered the areas that we might be considered for this infrastructure measure to see which ones were the highest priorities, and we asked people to choose.

99
00:17:00.700 --> 00:17:06.200
David Mermin: So, now, these percentages add up to more than 100%, because people were allowed to choose more than one.

100
00:17:06.650 --> 00:17:17.630
David Mermin: And then we, you know, equalized, the responses, so that nobody was, was, nobody was… had more weight than anyone else.

101
00:17:17.670 --> 00:17:28.400
David Mermin: that there are people who've voted for multiple things, so we have percentages over 100% here. And, and again, we're looking for the relative priority. If you had to choose between these things.

102
00:17:28.530 --> 00:17:41.060
David Mermin: which ones would be the highest priority for you? And two of them emerged clearly at the top of this list, which are safeguarding critical infrastructure from the threats of climate change, including flooding and wildfires, at 35%,

103
00:17:41.750 --> 00:17:47.109
David Mermin: and increasing Berkeley's safety and accessibility by improving sidewalks, curb ramps, and pathways.

104
00:17:47.360 --> 00:17:50.879
David Mermin: Those two things, different versions of safety and,

105

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00:17:51.030 --> 00:18:06.440
David Mermin: protection, both at the top of this list, followed by a second tier of things that are also clearly important to voters, reducing pollution flowing to the bay and flood risk by installing green infrastructure, improving parks, playgrounds, recreation.

106
00:18:06.750 --> 00:18:17.649
David Mermin: and replacing public safety facilities that are at the end of their useful life, all of those getting more than 20% picking them as one of their top priorities. And then somewhat lower, the more specific, location-specific,

107
00:18:19.200 --> 00:18:22.840
David Mermin: areas here of improving the waterfront and the Civic Center.

108
00:18:23.050 --> 00:18:28.069
David Mermin: Still have some support, but lower relative in priority compared to those broader ones.

109
00:18:29.380 --> 00:18:43.680
David Mermin: Then we get to the actual ballot measure, and again, this is, we tried to, ask it in a form that, resembled what people would see on a ballot, as we have done previously, in measuring potential ballot measures for the city.

110
00:18:44.000 --> 00:18:47.239
David Mermin: And we find, fairly strong support.

111
00:18:47.790 --> 00:18:57.900
David Mermin: In the city for passing a general obligation bond, to invest in a series of infrastructure things, and we specified here, investing in fire stations, emergency response.

112
00:18:58.320 --> 00:19:03.050
David Mermin: Parks and Recreation, Climate Change Resiliency, and Public Buildings and Infrastructure.

113
00:19:03.160 --> 00:19:10.480
David Mermin: And we had… we'll get to the two versions in a minute, but overall, this is the combined split sample across the whole city.

114
00:19:10.870 --> 00:19:14.959

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David Mermin: Our total result was 70% voting yes.

115
00:19:15.300 --> 00:19:23.310
David Mermin: And we also measured intensity of support, so you have 39% saying strongly yes, so some of that 70% would need to

116
00:19:23.770 --> 00:19:38.159
David Mermin: be consolidated if this measure were to pass, but it does look like it's currently 70%, 7 out of 10 voters in the city saying I would either vote for or lean yes on voting for that measure. Only 13% saying they would vote or lean no.

117
00:19:38.830 --> 00:19:46.519
David Mermin: It's a wide margin in favor of yes, but it does, importantly cross that two-thirds threshold, being over 67%.

118
00:19:47.450 --> 00:19:53.620
David Mermin: And then you have 16% say I'm undecided and not sure which way they would lean upon that infrastructure measure.

119
00:19:53.880 --> 00:20:08.889
David Mermin: So that's the total combined, and obviously it is… does reach over the threshold. This is the experiment we did with the size of the measure, and this was interesting because we would expect, given that we… there was a tax associated with this.

120
00:20:09.040 --> 00:20:10.649
David Mermin: Attacks level.

121
00:20:12.630 --> 00:20:23.009
David Mermin: that the one with the lower amount might be slightly more popular, because it would have a lower… it doesn't include a lower tax increase. Turns out, however, that there is essentially no difference.

122
00:20:23.330 --> 00:20:31.570
David Mermin: In the total yes vote, and if anything, the larger measure at the $300 million threshold tests slightly better, slightly higher.

123
00:20:31.810 --> 00:20:38.000
David Mermin: vote support. Now, this is well within the margin of error. As far as we know, there's essentially no difference here, but 71%.

124

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00:20:38.460 --> 00:20:45.110
David Mermin: for the $300 million bond measure, and 70% voting yes for the $200 million odd measure.

125
00:20:45.370 --> 00:20:55.320
David Mermin: 12 or 14% voting no, similar amounts, undecided. So, it does not appear to be particularly sensitive to the level, at least in this range.

126
00:20:55.850 --> 00:20:57.809
David Mermin: Of, the size of the bond.

127
00:20:58.710 --> 00:21:06.210
David Mermin: So that was the… so this was the combined at 70% yes. This was the split sample of the two different dollar amounts.

128
00:21:07.150 --> 00:21:20.849
David Mermin: And then we asked another, we then tested some arguments, and in the full report, you see the language in these arguments, but basically the idea was we wanted to see what happened when people learned more and heard more about the infrastructure measure, and we tested a

129
00:21:20.850 --> 00:21:27.570
David Mermin: It's a stress test, essentially, of the support, because it's both an argument in favor and an argument against.

130
00:21:27.990 --> 00:21:32.190
David Mermin: And we wanted to see, okay, if people hear arguments from both sides of this issue.

131
00:21:32.520 --> 00:21:44.839
David Mermin: would their vote shift? And it does shift a little, and it does shift slightly down, so it started at 70% overall, after that argument back and forth, and gave equal time to the yes and no arguments.

132
00:21:44.840 --> 00:21:59.189
David Mermin: the yes vote saying these are important infrastructure needs, and we need to invest, and it will… that will produce benefits for all of us in Berkeley, and the no argument essentially saying this costs too much, we can… we need to find the money elsewhere, we can't afford tax increases at this time.

133
00:21:59.810 --> 00:22:18.859

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David Mermin: And so, hearing those two arguments, here's where people ended up. Still two-thirds voting yes, just barely over the threshold, 67%, 18% voting no, and still 14% undecided. So, if any proportion of those undecideds were to break toward a yes, it would once again be well over the threshold.

134
00:22:18.930 --> 00:22:35.629
David Mermin: But it, you know, it's close, but certainly in a position to pass, with 67% voting yes after those arguments, and that does reinforce that this is a fairly robust finding in favor of people, supporting the measure, of Berkeley voters supporting this ballot measure.

135
00:22:36.130 --> 00:22:41.760
David Mermin: The other measure we tested on this community survey had to do with the sales tax, and this was,

136
00:22:42.170 --> 00:22:47.809
David Mermin: Not for those infrastructure investments, but more broadly to address the city's structural budget deficit.

137
00:22:48.500 --> 00:22:54.940
David Mermin: With all of the increases in costs for programs and the fact that the revenues are not keeping up.

138
00:22:55.290 --> 00:23:00.659
David Mermin: So the idea was to see if voters would support increasing the sales tax by half a percent.

139
00:23:01.150 --> 00:23:11.539
David Mermin: And in this version of it, we simply said, here's what… here's what it would be invested in, and here's what the cost would be. Would you vote yes or no? And 60%

140
00:23:12.030 --> 00:23:17.650
David Mermin: would vote yes on a sales tax increase to invest in these, budget needs for the city.

141
00:23:18.410 --> 00:23:25.619
David Mermin: That is, again, it's lower than the support for the infrastructure bond, but it is well above the 50% threshold that would be needed to pass.

142

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00:23:26.010 --> 00:23:28.630
David Mermin: 49% say they would vote no.

143
00:23:29.170 --> 00:23:39.009
David Mermin: But that is a substantial 31-point margin in favor, and you do have 11% who say they would be undecided. This is a pattern that suggests that this would be likely to pass.

144
00:23:39.240 --> 00:23:44.230
David Mermin: Given just the simple information of what's on the ballot for a sales tax measure.

145
00:23:44.690 --> 00:23:50.400
David Mermin: And again, we stress-tested this by testing the arguments in favor and opposed.

146
00:23:50.550 --> 00:23:56.740
David Mermin: About the favor… in favor argument, arguing about what the needs are for the city, and the importance of investing in these

147
00:23:57.270 --> 00:24:10.899
David Mermin: these budget needs, and the no argument, again, raising the question of, is this… does this cost too much? Is there other money that could be used? And specifically suggesting that a sales tax would be regressive.

148
00:24:11.350 --> 00:24:16.410
David Mermin: So they've heard those strong, arguments in favor and opposed, and again.

149
00:24:16.570 --> 00:24:26.330
David Mermin: Overall support dips a little bit from that initial measure of 60%, but is still well over a majority at 58% yes, after hearing his arguments, pro and con.

150
00:24:26.440 --> 00:24:28.710
David Mermin: 29% say they would vote no.

151
00:24:28.960 --> 00:24:30.400
David Mermin: 13%.

152
00:24:30.800 --> 00:24:39.509

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David Mermin: in the poll are undecided, as to whether they would, vote yes or no on the sales tax. So again, this would suggest it's in a good position to pass.

153
00:24:40.000 --> 00:24:46.660
David Mermin: And even if he undecided is broke to vote no on this case, it would still be well over the 50% threshold.

154
00:24:47.730 --> 00:25:01.230
David Mermin: And then finally, we tested a series, back to the infrastructure question, we tested a series of priorities in terms of what was most important. We had the broader priorities up top, now we asked about very specific things to invest in.

155
00:25:01.540 --> 00:25:07.629
David Mermin: With an infrastructure measure, once voters understood we're talking about an actual measure that might produce,

156
00:25:07.890 --> 00:25:19.669
David Mermin: revenue that could be used for these infrastructure investments. And in this case, rather than choose, everyone was able to rate each item on the list, and then they… they had a scale.

157
00:25:19.720 --> 00:25:31.839
David Mermin: five levels of how important it was, extremely important being the highest level, and we're rank ordering here the things in terms of the percent who rated them extremely important. And there were four things in particular

158
00:25:31.840 --> 00:25:48.659
David Mermin: that had the highest percentages of people saying they are extremely important to me to invest in that. The number one was renovating the 911 dispatch center to handle higher call volumes and modernize critical infrastructure, 29%. See, that is extremely important. That was the number one.

159
00:25:48.980 --> 00:25:52.559
David Mermin: On this long battery of potential investments.

160
00:25:52.840 --> 00:26:09.679
David Mermin: Second highest was making the fire stations citywide safer and more energy efficient by replacing fire stations, and they're no longer able to meet demands. And notably, when we said replacing fire

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stations, that tested a little higher than repairing fire stations, so that was notable, and that was a high priority for Berkeley voters.

161
00:26:10.110 --> 00:26:21.619
David Mermin: Also tied with that, as the second highest priority was improving safety and accessibility by repairing cracked and uneven sidewalks and upgrading curb ramps. 27% extremely important for that one.

162
00:26:21.700 --> 00:26:36.639
David Mermin: And then also in the top tier here, just a couple points lower in terms of extreme importance, is upgrading the deteriorating public restrooms at Berkeley Parks. And in this case, it was upgrading and repairing rather than building new public restrooms that tested a little bit higher.

163
00:26:36.770 --> 00:26:40.339
David Mermin: Upgrading a little bit higher than, than, building new ones.

164
00:26:40.830 --> 00:26:52.269
David Mermin: This is the full list, just to show the range of things that we tested specifically that could be investments out of the infrastructure bond, but those four noted at the top.

165
00:26:52.360 --> 00:26:57.949
David Mermin: Did have the highest overall, as well as the highest, extremely important rating.

166
00:26:57.950 --> 00:27:17.160
David Mermin: But you see several other things not too far below that, repairing the fire stations, earthquake protections, waterfront paths, repairing public buildings, which does include the Civic Center. Remember, when we limited the buildings just to the Civic Center, that rated lower. When we say more broadly, repairing public buildings, including the Civic Center, that did better.

167
00:27:17.240 --> 00:27:25.580
David Mermin: So all of those are in fairly high levels, but those top 4 or 5 stand out above the others in terms of what voters are most focused on in terms of

168
00:27:25.680 --> 00:27:27.060
David Mermin: investments

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169
00:27:27.670 --> 00:27:36.059
David Mermin: And those are the… that's the summary of the findings, but happy to take questions or other feedback, after… after this presentation.

170
00:27:38.740 --> 00:27:40.170
Boardroom: Thank you, David.

171
00:27:40.670 --> 00:27:45.539
Boardroom: I feel like I'm gonna have to call you both something different to differentiate.

172
00:27:45.540 --> 00:27:52.350
David Mermin: A lot of David's here, but we're used to it. David and I are in similar generations, we've grown up a lot of David, so I'm sure we're used to it.

173
00:27:52.350 --> 00:28:05.140
Boardroom: Okay. Very good. Do I have any questions from our council members? Do you want to pause and focus on the survey before we finish, or… I'm sorry, yes, if you want to go ahead. Okay.

174
00:28:06.330 --> 00:28:07.949
Boardroom: Oh, good to see the presenter? Sorry.

175
00:28:10.010 --> 00:28:13.140
Boardroom: So, we'll be real quick,

176
00:28:13.690 --> 00:28:32.739
Boardroom: So, in addition to the, community survey, I want to give a lot of credit to Director Farrish, who's in the audience, Director Davis, Chief Sprague, Carrie to my left, and I don't know how many staff to thank, but there are many, in our Parks, Recreation, Waterfront Department, Public Works, and Fire Department.

177
00:28:32.830 --> 00:28:37.440
Boardroom: That have worked really, really hard to implement a very robust community engagement campaign.

178
00:28:37.660 --> 00:28:55.949
Boardroom: And what this slide highlights for you is the breadth of the work, that they've engaged in. They've been in front of six city

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commissions, and I'm really encouraged by that because I've started to see commissions develop reports for Council to provide advice, on how to move forward with the general obligation bond.

179
00:28:56.130 --> 00:29:01.159
Boardroom: Four community focus groups. We have one more that's going to be occurring this week.

180
00:29:01.480 --> 00:29:09.260
Boardroom: Four… sorry, four community focus groups, and then four joint district community meetings, and we have one more joint district community meeting this week.

181
00:29:09.300 --> 00:29:21.309
Boardroom: And then we've developed the city webpage, as well as an email to receive input, from the community. And all of this, right, all the results of all this community engagement, the results of the community survey.

182
00:29:21.310 --> 00:29:31.179
Boardroom: are gonna inform us bringing back the list to you, in May, that hopefully, we'll get blessing to move forward with. And I'll talk a little bit more about that in a second.

183
00:29:32.380 --> 00:29:36.379
Boardroom: So when you look at the timeline, in next steps,

184
00:29:36.540 --> 00:29:44.400
Boardroom: So we engaged and embarked on this journey in December of last year, and that was kicked off with the work session that we brought, before you.

185
00:29:44.580 --> 00:30:00.979
Boardroom: And following that, we brought on, like, street partners to help us with the community survey, and as I mentioned, staff developed a very robust community engagement campaign. And that's what brought us forward to this day here today, in which we're bringing forward the results of that first survey. And undoubtedly, they're very encouraging.

186
00:30:01.370 --> 00:30:15.949
Boardroom: Subsequent to the direction we received tonight, our goal is to come back before Council in the May timeframe. If we get direction to move forward with a second survey, which is one of our recommended actions, we would bring those results back in front of you.

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187
00:30:16.030 --> 00:30:25.180
Boardroom: In addition to that, it is our goal, and our interest in bringing forward a refined project list, again, reflecting the input of the community survey.

188
00:30:25.180 --> 00:30:42.879
Boardroom: Reflecting the input of the community engagement effort that's underway. In addition to that, we are refining the cost estimates that are developed for those projects, as well as considering the staffing organization and the staffing architecture that needs to be in place to deliver a bond of this magnitude efficiently and successfully.

189
00:30:42.880 --> 00:30:47.820
Boardroom: And our hope is in that May study session, we would get direction on that final project list.

190
00:30:47.900 --> 00:30:58.700
Boardroom: Which will also help inform our city attorney's office. It is an integral role in helping to develop the ballot language that ultimately we'd like to bring in front of you in the June timeframe, of this year.

191
00:30:58.990 --> 00:31:11.150
Boardroom: So that kind of outlines sort of where we are today and where we're headed. I'll now turn to the conclusion, which is our recommended actions. We have 3 actions, that we would like to bring before you this evening.

192
00:31:11.240 --> 00:31:19.379
Boardroom: The first one is to give us direction to actually develop the final, ballot language for the $300 million general obligation bond.

193
00:31:19.660 --> 00:31:27.000
Boardroom: To develop the draft ballot language for the sales and use tax, and then to give us direction to go back out and do a second community survey.

194
00:31:27.630 --> 00:31:38.220
Boardroom: And I want to point out what that second community survey would consist of. One, we would actually like to test the actual ballot language that would be on the ballot itself. It's really important for us to get that feedback.

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195
00:31:38.290 --> 00:31:58.190
Boardroom: And secondly, in taking direction from the Council, one of the things that you were interested in was seeing the interaction of these measures with other measures that could be on the ballot. And so, obviously, as time has passed, we're getting better clarity on what are some of the items that could actually be on the ballot, and so we would like to integrate that into a second community survey to see where things shank out after that.

196
00:31:58.600 --> 00:32:08.589
Boardroom: That concludes our presentation, and as David Merman said, he's available and his team for questions, as well as myself and other staff that are either online or in audience. Thank you.

197
00:32:09.240 --> 00:32:11.390
Boardroom: Very good, thank you very much.

198
00:32:11.560 --> 00:32:16.760
Boardroom: Alright, back to questions. Does anyone have any questions? Oh…

199
00:32:16.910 --> 00:32:21.000
Boardroom: This says one, but doesn't say who it is, so…

200
00:32:21.120 --> 00:32:27.959
Boardroom: I'm not sure. Perhaps? Okay, I'll take Councilmember Trake up first time.

201
00:32:31.850 --> 00:32:35.360
Boardroom: I don't want to go second.

202
00:32:35.730 --> 00:32:39.660
Boardroom: No, thank you so much for the presentation,

203
00:32:40.160 --> 00:32:49.709
Boardroom: I have 3 questions, I think all of them are for David, David Moorman. Thank you, thank you so much.

204
00:32:53.100 --> 00:32:57.480
Boardroom: As far as, in… After…

205

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00:32:57.670 --> 00:33:09.120
Boardroom: I guess what's called the battery of, positive and negative, statements. The measure is at 67% in your…

206
00:33:09.240 --> 00:33:19.550
Boardroom: Experience, what kind of factors and what is… that might influence,

207
00:33:19.920 --> 00:33:34.550
Boardroom: That kind of polling, and how a measure does on the ballot, whether directionally it goes up or down, so what factors influence whether it goes up or down, and also,

208
00:33:35.100 --> 00:33:42.769
Boardroom: In your experience, how often does it go up versus down? .

209
00:33:43.080 --> 00:33:53.360
David Mermin: That's question number one. Maybe I will… Sure, let me start with that. So, three things, that we think, that play a role in that.

210
00:33:53.500 --> 00:34:05.669
David Mermin: Keeping in mind, as always, and pollsters are always going to say this, right, that there is, this is a snapshot in time. We took this survey in February of 2026, elections in November of 2026,

211
00:34:05.830 --> 00:34:23.519
David Mermin: things happen, right? There are events, there are news… there is news. Since we took this poll, you know, the country started a war overseas, right, lots of things can change and affect the environment, right, in which people are making their decisions.

212
00:34:23.969 --> 00:34:32.759
David Mermin: We don't know that, you know, a war overseas is going to affect how people vote on infrastructure in Berkeley, but sometimes things like that do, right, and other things in the environment.

213
00:34:33.170 --> 00:34:36.339
David Mermin: In terms of what people are voting on in the election, so there's that.

214
00:34:36.739 --> 00:34:42.150

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David Mermin: The second thing that can influence is exactly what the specific language on the ballot is.

215
00:34:42.270 --> 00:34:43.730
David Mermin: Berkeley voters are…

216
00:34:44.219 --> 00:34:54.660
David Mermin: well-educated, attentive, relative to most voters in a lot of other places. They tend to read the measure. They tend to have very specific reactions to the very specific things that they are

217
00:34:54.770 --> 00:35:09.289
David Mermin: presented with, and that's one of the reasons we're recommending a second survey when we have actual language to test that would read exactly as the learners would see it, and sometimes there's an element in there that either boosts or undercuts the level of support.

218
00:35:09.390 --> 00:35:24.719
David Mermin: And then, in the third, there's the question of the specific… the ballot environment. So the broader environment of the world and politics, but there's the specific environment of what else people are voting on on the ballot, which is another reason to have a second survey to

219
00:35:24.840 --> 00:35:33.049
David Mermin: now we have a clearer sense of exactly what voters will be looking at on that ballot in Alameda County, in Berkeley, which

220
00:35:33.180 --> 00:35:36.620
David Mermin: Other revenue measures in particular they might be asked to vote on.

221
00:35:37.090 --> 00:35:44.060
David Mermin: that kind of, you know, you can get an effect where people feel like, wow, I voted for 3 or 4 taxes already, am I ready to vote for another one?

222
00:35:44.990 --> 00:35:47.049
David Mermin: So we do want to see

223
00:35:47.220 --> 00:35:56.179

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David Mermin: how that might play out relative to the support. And since, of course, the support here is slightly above, but just slightly above the threshold it would need to pass.

224
00:35:56.240 --> 00:36:13.079
David Mermin: you know, it's important, right, whether it goes up or down, as your question indicates. In the past, the last thing I would say is that in the past, in the City of Berkeley, we have more often than not seen the level increase from when we polled in the… early in the year and in winter and spring to the fall ballot.

225
00:36:14.050 --> 00:36:21.229
David Mermin: But there have been a couple of years where that wasn't the case, where there were either shifts in the environment or a lot of other revenue measures, and for instance.

226
00:36:21.740 --> 00:36:33.289
David Mermin: In 2022, as many of you know, there was about… there were a couple of revenue measures in the city. Those were measured ahead of time. They went… ended up getting about the level of vote that was

227
00:36:33.460 --> 00:36:36.450
David Mermin: Expected in the poll, but they did not increase.

228
00:36:36.670 --> 00:36:48.959
David Mermin: and as a result, actually fell a couple points short of passage. So… so it's… it has really gone… I haven't seen this type of measure, which is generally investments in the city, go down, particularly in Berkeley, but we have seen it

229
00:36:49.140 --> 00:36:54.689
David Mermin: kind of hold steady or erode within a couple of points, and that would matter in this case. So… so those are…

230
00:36:54.820 --> 00:36:56.549
David Mermin: A couple of things to look at.

231
00:36:57.760 --> 00:37:00.269
Boardroom: Thank you, and then…

232
00:37:00.700 --> 00:37:05.409
Boardroom: I have two, I think, related questions,

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233
00:37:06.440 --> 00:37:11.370
Boardroom: In the slide deck, you first ask about,

234
00:37:12.330 --> 00:37:18.049
Boardroom: Top priorities, and then later on, you have a more granular slide.

235
00:37:18.160 --> 00:37:24.990
Boardroom: And there seems to be a bit of a mismatch, specifically,

236
00:37:25.400 --> 00:37:35.729
Boardroom: you know, I think you called us out, the, the buildings adjacent to Civic Center Park, Paul, lower in the,

237
00:37:35.780 --> 00:37:47.139
Boardroom: more high-level survey, but they are formally, within the top tier range, and maybe you answered this, by saying.

238
00:37:47.520 --> 00:37:56.290
Boardroom: In the latter case, all, buildings, or seismic for all buildings is included, including those

239
00:37:56.320 --> 00:38:10.349
Boardroom: adjacent to Civic Center Park, but I was hoping you could speak to that more, because I did see some other mismatches there, specifically around, you know, parks, or dog parks, .

240
00:38:11.270 --> 00:38:12.490
David Mermin: What?

241
00:38:12.490 --> 00:38:12.860
Boardroom: the app.

242
00:38:12.860 --> 00:38:13.280
David Mermin: Yeah.

243
00:38:13.420 --> 00:38:17.740
Boardroom: Mean in the second, bar chart.

244
00:38:19.010 --> 00:38:30.269

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David Mermin: Right, so, these were slightly different questions, so… to note one thing, right? That the first question was, here are 6 or 7 broad areas

245
00:38:30.500 --> 00:38:32.319
David Mermin: for infrastructure investment.

246
00:38:32.400 --> 00:38:44.470
David Mermin: you please choose and tell us which one or two of these is most important to you, right? So people couldn't, even if they cared about Civic Center buildings or dog parks or whatever, they couldn't say.

247
00:38:44.540 --> 00:38:59.740
David Mermin: but they cared more about fire stations and sidewalk safety, they couldn't choose both, they had to pick, right? And when they were forced to pick, they picked what we identify as the sort of safety-related items, emergency services, as well as the sidewalks.

248
00:39:00.170 --> 00:39:13.079
David Mermin: And and so that's one difference. And then the second difference, and I think this was… we deliberately designed this in because we were curious about the… we know there's been back and forth about the Civic Center investment.

249
00:39:13.480 --> 00:39:17.060
David Mermin: in the past, When we just said.

250
00:39:17.240 --> 00:39:24.100
David Mermin: fix these buildings in the Civic Center, and it was in that set of choices. It just, you know, people might…

251
00:39:24.210 --> 00:39:41.250
David Mermin: be happy to do that, but they clearly didn't think it was as high a priority break as those other items. Then in the longer list, they were able to rate each of those, and for each one, say, how important is it to you? Now, keep in mind, that infrastructure, that piece of repairing the buildings was not at the time

252
00:39:42.050 --> 00:39:45.120
David Mermin: But it wasn't at the bottom, either. It was right in the… it was sort of in the middle.

253
00:39:45.610 --> 00:39:52.639

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David Mermin: And it was in the… and it was framed… the description was different. The description said, we're going to invest in public buildings around the city.

254
00:39:53.670 --> 00:39:59.600
David Mermin: that are used for various kinds of services, including the Civic Center, and I mentioned three… two or three other things.

255
00:39:59.780 --> 00:40:13.149
David Mermin: So, those were the two differences, and I think account for that one. And I think you can see in areas like parks some of those differences as well. Like, when we got very narrow as to, we're gonna fix, we're gonna provide dog parks, people are like.

256
00:40:13.680 --> 00:40:30.189
David Mermin: fine, but that is not my highest priority, right? It's fine, right? So it wound up lower on that relative list, but when we said more broadly, we want to invest in parks, it was something people care about, so… and then we had… when we said specifically bathrooms and fixed those, it's actually one of the highest.

257
00:40:30.290 --> 00:40:36.879
David Mermin: Right, so by having that granular breakdown, we're able to see a little more what people mean when they say, yes, I want to improve the parks.

258
00:40:37.230 --> 00:40:49.580
David Mermin: But focus on these areas as compared to those. So that's just useful. And again, that doesn't mean you can only do the three things that voters care most about, but it does suggest that in

259
00:40:49.610 --> 00:41:01.189
David Mermin: Describing and listing the priorities and talking about what the city's priorities are for this investment, that you might want to note the things that the voters care most about.

260
00:41:02.320 --> 00:41:05.839
Boardroom: Thank you, and then what do the asterisks mean?

261
00:41:07.000 --> 00:41:09.880
David Mermin: In… yeah, so in that,

262
00:41:09.990 --> 00:41:17.079

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David Mermin: let me go down here. Those… we… whenever we split sampled, so remember we did this split sample?

263
00:41:17.570 --> 00:41:21.379
David Mermin: In the, bond measure, we had two different dollar amounts.

264
00:41:21.820 --> 00:41:26.370
David Mermin: And that literally means people randomly get either one version or the other version of the question.

265
00:41:26.520 --> 00:41:30.820
David Mermin: And we can then… that allows us to basically get two questions for the price of one.

266
00:41:31.320 --> 00:41:39.700
David Mermin: And people… and we can also compare. And so, in that list of projects, partly for time, but also to do some experiments with language.

267
00:41:39.840 --> 00:41:52.800
David Mermin: we split some of those questions. So, for instance, we had replace fire stations… one item there that was replace, you know, address the fire stations that are outdated by replacing them.

268
00:41:53.120 --> 00:41:56.920
David Mermin: Versus address the fire stations that are outdated by repairing them.

269
00:41:57.270 --> 00:42:03.659
David Mermin: So we split sampled, people heard only one or the other, so they didn't know that they were hearing two versions, they just heard one.

270
00:42:04.190 --> 00:42:13.380
David Mermin: But by testing it that way, we could then measure on both, and it turns out, if you heard, replace fire stations, you're 5 points higher and saying extremely important.

271
00:42:13.530 --> 00:42:22.999
David Mermin: than if you heard repair fire stations. So that produces that recommendation, then, to say, replacing is better language when you're talking about what needs to

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272
00:42:23.150 --> 00:42:32.279
David Mermin: what needs to be done with the fire stations. And likewise, on park restrooms, that's also got an asterisk, because we split sampled. We had a version that said.

273
00:42:32.420 --> 00:42:34.790
David Mermin: Upgrade them and fix them.

274
00:42:35.300 --> 00:42:39.960
David Mermin: And another one that said, add… add new ones.

275
00:42:40.510 --> 00:42:51.770
David Mermin: And the add new ones was kind of in the lower half of the priorities, but the upgrade and fix the existing park restrooms was quite high, so that was another interesting experiment that we did with the split sample.

276
00:42:52.970 --> 00:42:54.070
Boardroom: Thank you so much.

277
00:42:55.440 --> 00:43:01.289
Boardroom: Thank you. So, I'm gonna go Councilmember O'Keefe, Councilmember Brockaby, and then go to Councilmember Humbert.

278
00:43:01.440 --> 00:43:05.840
Boardroom: So, go ahead, Councilmember O'Keefe. Thank you.

279
00:43:06.590 --> 00:43:11.579
Boardroom: I was wondering, I guess this is for the Deputy City Manager, or whoever wants to answer,

280
00:43:12.510 --> 00:43:25.480
Boardroom: If you could say a little bit about how each of these, the bond measure and also the sales tax measure, could address our structural deficit? I think it's more straightforward to the sales tax, but if you could comment on that, and then I'm also curious

281
00:43:25.880 --> 00:43:28.899
Boardroom: How the bond measure might… change things.

282
00:43:32.610 --> 00:43:33.930

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Boardroom: I can start.

283
00:43:34.030 --> 00:43:36.959
Boardroom: And then pass it off. So,

284
00:43:37.120 --> 00:43:41.860
Boardroom: The… the sales and use tax increase of a half cent.

285
00:43:42.250 --> 00:43:47.439
Boardroom: is estimated to bring in around $9 billion a year. And…

286
00:43:47.780 --> 00:43:56.099
Boardroom: Currently, our structural deficit is somewhere in the neighborhood of $27 to $30 million for 27, and again, for 28. And so,

287
00:43:56.290 --> 00:44:06.960
Boardroom: We're in the process now of putting together budget reduction scenarios, that include a lot of, the reduction of a lot of staff positions, some filled, some vacant.

288
00:44:07.030 --> 00:44:21.440
Boardroom: And spread throughout the whole city, including public safety. And so, were this measure… were the absent sales tax increase to pass, we would be able to mitigate some of the reductions to, our public safety,

289
00:44:21.650 --> 00:44:24.700
Boardroom: Units, both in police and in fire.

290
00:44:25.360 --> 00:44:27.140
Boardroom: a $300 million…

291
00:44:27.890 --> 00:44:47.099
Boardroom: general obligation bond for infrastructure. That's not so much focused on, like, a budget reduction, although, of course, we would be hiring engineers and a lot of staff to do the work, because it is a lot of work, and part of our budget deficit challenge in public works includes shifting a lot of people off of general fund and into special funds.

292
00:44:47.100 --> 00:44:48.060
Boardroom: And so…

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293
00:44:48.080 --> 00:44:59.219
Boardroom: if we add more special fund dollars through this measure to address the infrastructure needs that we have, we would be able to, you know, offset some of those staff challenges, I would say.

294
00:44:59.540 --> 00:45:16.070
Boardroom: I don't know if you want to add a little bit to that. And I would just add, particularly around the infrastructure bond, you know, one of the things that we're very attuned to is that because of the age of our facilities, you know, if we cannot invest in them, we're going to be subject to facility closure, service disruptions, and so I can give

295
00:45:16.120 --> 00:45:24.700
Boardroom: you know, just some really tangible examples. Like, right now, we don't have a hot water heater at South Berkeley Senior Center, right? It's completely embarrassing and inappropriate, but…

296
00:45:24.700 --> 00:45:36.219
Boardroom: You know, these are the things that we're falling behind on, and this bond will allow us to invest, not in all of our infrastructure, but will allow us to adjust certain facilities, and get us on the pathway of being proactive in certain regards.

297
00:45:36.230 --> 00:45:47.559
Boardroom: So that's just a really poignant example in my mind, and as the city manager said, you know, as we're looking at these budget reductions, which is about 10% of our general fund, so it's a very heavy burden,

298
00:45:48.150 --> 00:45:58.270
Boardroom: This sales tax measure gives us the capacity to think about what can be preserved, in order to keep the city operating at a level that this council and the community expects.

299
00:46:00.420 --> 00:46:03.079
Boardroom: Great, thank you, that's really helpful.

300
00:46:03.750 --> 00:46:16.059
Boardroom: I was also wondering if you could… anyone could comment on how, both, once again, for both the bond and sales tax measures, how should these both pass? How would…

301
00:46:16.570 --> 00:46:22.570

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Boardroom: The tax burden on our citizens compare with that of neighboring cities?

302
00:46:23.780 --> 00:46:27.910
Boardroom: So we haven't, completed an analysis of…

303
00:46:28.240 --> 00:46:47.310
Boardroom: So, we can look at it from the perspective of this fiscal year. We don't necessarily have profile on what other jurisdictions are thinking about for their ballot for this upcoming election. So we know we're about in line, right, next to Oakland and Albany in terms of what our,

304
00:46:47.750 --> 00:46:54.570
Boardroom: What our total property tax bill looks like, and we can sort of do some hypothetical modeling of what a bond would look like.

305
00:46:54.740 --> 00:47:08.910
Boardroom: The $300 million bond, is about $22, per $100,000 of assessed value, and so for the median assessed value home of $550,000, that's about $100 a year on the property tax bill.

306
00:47:10.140 --> 00:47:26.610
Boardroom: And I can add just a little bit more on the sales and use tax, I can't remember if you said that, but… so we're at 10.25%, and this would put us kind of in line with cities that are around us, so Oakland's at 10.75, the city of Albany's at 10.75, San Leandro Hayward, 10.75, so it kind of puts us in that range.

307
00:47:27.040 --> 00:47:31.390
Boardroom: it would make us equal to those places, yeah. Correct. That's great, thank you.

308
00:47:31.520 --> 00:47:36.199
Boardroom: I have more questions, I'll just… I'll limit myself to 3.

309
00:47:36.380 --> 00:47:44.540
Boardroom: Oh yeah, it's kind of a fun one. Given that the…

310
00:47:45.040 --> 00:47:57.020
Boardroom: support didn't really change, or even arguably went up when we went from 200 to 300 million. I was wondering if a higher number was

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considered, or will be considered. Just, you know, what's the… how far can we take this?

311
00:47:58.650 --> 00:48:03.770
David Mermin: I can address that from a public opinion point of view, which is we don't know, and it…

312
00:48:03.920 --> 00:48:05.690
David Mermin: is generally

313
00:48:05.740 --> 00:48:16.180
David Mermin: Historically, when we have tested higher dollar amounts with a higher tax increase, that has tended to be somewhat, you know, reduce the support gradually.

314
00:48:16.180 --> 00:48:29.640
David Mermin: Depending on how high you go, we don't know whether that would be the case here, but it's probable that it would. And of course, since this is just a few points above the threshold, even though there does appear to be an appetite for this

315
00:48:30.250 --> 00:48:37.470
David Mermin: higher level, $300 million over $200 million. There's certainly clear recommendation here that $300 million would be fine.

316
00:48:39.050 --> 00:48:52.699
David Mermin: But, we just… the answer is we don't know. We wanted to test, you know, versions that we thought were realistic, and that was just a, you know, a joint decision as we were working this together with the city staff as to what were the likely levels to test, because we…

317
00:48:52.700 --> 00:49:01.979
David Mermin: Unfortunately, with one survey instrument, you can't test the whole range. It gets very, very complicated and messes up the accuracy of the sample if you do that too much.

318
00:49:04.760 --> 00:49:06.000
Boardroom: Can I ask if…

319
00:49:06.690 --> 00:49:17.309
Boardroom: I mean, we're… it sounds like we're gonna poll again, so is there any interest, or are we just, like… I mean, how did we come up with

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the $300 million? Maybe that's a bigger question, I don't need an extensive answer.

320
00:49:20.220 --> 00:49:25.760
Boardroom: I mean, if you all want us to test at a higher rate, we certainly could. We felt like…

321
00:49:26.020 --> 00:49:34.350
Boardroom: $300 million was… It felt like a lot. And also, you know, when you think about

322
00:49:34.910 --> 00:49:39.970
Boardroom: $22 per $100,000 of assessed value, that seems kind of a reasonable amount.

323
00:49:42.070 --> 00:49:44.129
Boardroom: There's… it's not like a science.

324
00:49:45.380 --> 00:49:50.929
Boardroom: Okay, I'm not suggesting we should, I was just kind of curious what the process was, and if that's being contemplated still.

325
00:49:52.010 --> 00:49:54.990
Boardroom: Actually, sorry, I had one more question.

326
00:49:55.660 --> 00:50:00.380
Boardroom: It's, for, David M,

327
00:50:01.600 --> 00:50:04.449
Boardroom: in the results, I'm curious if…

328
00:50:04.810 --> 00:50:11.679
Boardroom: There were any, demographics, or parts of town, or any sort of,

329
00:50:12.120 --> 00:50:21.940
Boardroom: human patterns that showed a difference in support levels, like a particular part of town, or renters, or anything like that that showed a significant statistical difference.

330
00:50:22.300 --> 00:50:29.919

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David Mermin: I will not give you the… there's a… there's a very long answer to that question, which is mostly provided in the report with simple tables and breakdowns of that.

331
00:50:30.800 --> 00:50:43.630
David Mermin: We'll try to give that here. The short version is that the variation, I think, was less than we normally see, in the sense that the levels of support were fairly consistent across the major regions of the city.

332
00:50:44.330 --> 00:51:00.080
David Mermin: With a sample this size, you can't break down, like, individual council districts or, you know, that level of granularity, but we did broadly do a sort of Berkeley Hills as central, south, central and south together, and then a West Berkeley as kind of three broad areas.

333
00:51:00.160 --> 00:51:05.170
David Mermin: And notably, there were not huge differences in the levels of support.

334
00:51:05.970 --> 00:51:10.069
David Mermin: And actually, even though Hills tends to have

335
00:51:10.570 --> 00:51:24.279
David Mermin: you know, more homeowners, higher property values. They… they were not particularly more resistant to the increase, and in fact, were more supportive of certain aspects of the increase compared to the rest of the city. But they were… it was pretty solid across the board.

336
00:51:24.350 --> 00:51:41.270
David Mermin: And then other demographics, it is, often the case that younger voters and renters are a little more supportive of property taxes because they don't pay them as directly. There was a little bit of that pattern, but it was not a particularly big difference, in that.

337
00:51:42.610 --> 00:51:44.239
David Mermin: And then,

338
00:51:45.080 --> 00:51:56.839
David Mermin: Modest differences by gender, race, and some of the other measures, but nothing that was, like, jumped out as being, wow, here's a group that is super, super, super excited to do this, or a group that was particularly opposed.

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339
00:51:57.090 --> 00:52:03.989
David Mermin: There is a very small group of Republicans in Berkeley who are too small to break out on their own, but they generally tend to be against.

340
00:52:04.360 --> 00:52:05.709
David Mermin: Passive visits.

341
00:52:05.710 --> 00:52:07.689
Boardroom: That's not surprising, thanks.

342
00:52:07.940 --> 00:52:23.399
Boardroom: Yeah, and I appreciate you saying that, renters don't pay property taxes directly, because it's a common, common misunderstanding that they don't pay property taxes, and it is, factored into the rent, so I appreciate you being clear about that. Those are all my questions. Thank you very much.

343
00:52:24.190 --> 00:52:35.790
Boardroom: Thank you very much. Okay, moving on to Councilmember Blackaby, and then Councilmember Humbert. Great, thank you, Madam Mayor. In some ways, I might pick up a little bit from where Councilmember O'Keefe, excuse me, left off.

344
00:52:36.050 --> 00:52:43.320
Boardroom: To ask the Deputy City Manager. We've had a, I think, had a similar kind of back and forth in the Budget Committee.

345
00:52:43.670 --> 00:52:53.349
Boardroom: Big picture, looking at the fact, like, on slide 3, that we've got this $1.87 billion kind of, overall backlog on the infrastructure.

346
00:52:53.580 --> 00:53:02.140
Boardroom: And you've sort of identified how much we're investing in any given fiscal year through available funding, through FF funds, through the T1 spend down.

347
00:53:02.300 --> 00:53:13.679
Boardroom: I was just sort of doing back of the envelope, which is a little dangerous, but somewhere on the order of $60 to $70 million each year, we're kind of investing in infrastructure investment.

348

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00:53:14.160 --> 00:53:22.100
Boardroom: And the capital backlog continues to grow, even with that level of investment. Is that fair to say?

349
00:53:22.360 --> 00:53:31.760
Boardroom: Yeah, you know, I went, I want to credit Ray Yep. He shared with me a report, that was presented to the Council a couple years ago, looking at

350
00:53:32.000 --> 00:53:50.449
Boardroom: asset management and how we're maintaining our assets, and I, you know, don't have the statistics in the front of my mind, but it was interesting that when you really drill down and look at specific categories like parks and public facilities, you know, these numbers in terms of what we're spending on those buildings is even lower than this aggregate 2% amount.

351
00:53:50.450 --> 00:53:57.219
Boardroom: Which is really what's driving the increase in the, you know, the deferred and unfunded liabilities. Yeah.

352
00:53:59.070 --> 00:54:07.290
Boardroom: because, again, no one, I think, here is suggesting, hey, let's, you know, go for more. But I'm also thinking about,

353
00:54:07.390 --> 00:54:23.759
Boardroom: you know, what should we be thinking is the ideal target? Like, 20 years from now? Like, if we're at $1.87 billion backlog now, what are we trying to… where are we trying to get? Like, what's a healthy… I almost think of this as, like, in the national debt perspective, we always are going to carry some amount of national debt, it's just a question of how big it is.

354
00:54:23.880 --> 00:54:39.600
Boardroom: I guess as a city, we're always going to cover some sort of infrastructure, carry some sort of infrastructure backlog, but $1.8 billion seems like a lot. So I guess my question is, it's more like putting this in the context of, like, are we trying to drive this number down? Is this bond part of the solution to driving it down?

355
00:54:39.600 --> 00:54:43.900
Boardroom: And if so, how much do we need to be investing on an annual basis to be driving that number down?

356

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00:54:44.030 --> 00:54:56.939
Boardroom: That's… and so it's just, like I said, it looked like we're investing somewhere like 50 to 60 billion dollars… sorry, 50 to 60 million dollars on an annual basis. We're not quite keeping pace, like, we're falling a little bit farther behind each time.

357
00:54:57.130 --> 00:55:05.170
Boardroom: So if we invest… if we have this bond online, which I think is about $20 million a year, something like that, if it's $100 million of bonds over 5 years.

358
00:55:05.540 --> 00:55:11.529
Boardroom: 20 million. So I just at least want us to try and square this, like, is this number…

359
00:55:11.530 --> 00:55:17.089
Boardroom: gonna help us at least flatten the curve, if not start drying that down. I don't know if we have a good read on that, but…

360
00:55:17.090 --> 00:55:31.979
Boardroom: So I don't have a direct answer. I don't think this number is going to flatten the curve to the point at which we will… we could consider the amount that we're investing in our facilities is adequate. This is a start. This is getting us on the right path.

361
00:55:31.980 --> 00:55:41.920
Boardroom: I think, when you think about the city 5, 10, 15, 20, 25 years down the road, you know, I think about one of the referrals that Council brought forward to us, which is.

362
00:55:41.920 --> 00:55:55.550
Boardroom: Needing to develop a long-term vision for, you know, how are we going to not just go after this bond, but how are we going to regularly build into our financial model, a proactive, strategic approach?

363
00:55:55.550 --> 00:56:02.539
Boardroom: That allows us to continually go out to voters and have a plan of how we're gonna adjust our facilities. I think when we have

364
00:56:02.560 --> 00:56:20.680
Boardroom: that plan well defined for you will have a better answer to that question, because it's a very complex question. What I can honestly say, though, is that, you know, investing in our facilities, really

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addresses a number of different important boxes. One is, obviously, with aging infrastructure, there's liability and there's cost with that.

365
00:56:20.800 --> 00:56:36.550
Boardroom: There's an incredible amount of staff time that goes into addressing emergencies as they arise. Because we're addressing emergencies as they arise, we're spending more money than we should be spending by having a more efficient, up-to-date, effective facility. So,

366
00:56:36.680 --> 00:56:56.530
Boardroom: I want to have a specific answer for you, I don't have the number for you, but I can tell you that this is the beginning, and that there's a continual path that we have to come up with in terms of what we need to do over a longer period of time to get our arms around this unfunded liability. I'm eager to… yeah, I love seeing this in context, so I'm eager to continue that conversation at future meetings, just to kind of anchor this in, like.

367
00:56:56.570 --> 00:56:58.830
Boardroom: You know… In the big picture.

368
00:56:58.830 --> 00:57:19.620
Boardroom: we add this brick to the wall, how are we doing in terms of, you know, making progress on this? One other just quick thing to add, and this is probably an obvious point, but just to make it, is that the longer we defer the maintenance on all these projects, the more expensive they become, and so there is a, there is a cost efficiency and a benefit to addressing them earlier rather than later. So, you know, and as

369
00:57:19.640 --> 00:57:28.390
Boardroom: Deputy City Manager White said we haven't come up with an exact plan for what all that looks like, but, like, starting right now is important. Yeah, it's no regrets move to say we've got to

370
00:57:28.630 --> 00:57:39.549
Boardroom: get after it. It's just a question of how much more do we have to get after it, over what… over time. Okay, thank you. And, back to, David Merman,

371
00:57:39.940 --> 00:57:48.420
Boardroom: So we tested the sales tax and the bond measure together in this poll. When we were asking people questions about it, were they thinking about them…

372

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00:57:48.450 --> 00:58:01.650
Boardroom: together, or are they really thinking about them independently? And I guess maybe we'll get to this in the second survey, if we ask you to do it. But, like, is there a chance that, when we pulled this and did the research on this, people were thinking about one or the other?

373
00:58:01.700 --> 00:58:10.140
Boardroom: And weren't necessarily thinking that, hey, the city's gonna come ask for both a bond and a sales tax increase, and how might that affect the response over time?

374
00:58:10.140 --> 00:58:22.699
David Mermin: Yeah, so we were asking about them independently, right? We were asking, we'll just consider this measure on its own, and then we framed the question that way. Having said that, we also had to choose an order here, and the order we chose was to

375
00:58:22.930 --> 00:58:29.069
David Mermin: Do the infrastructure measure first, because it was more complicated and had more items related to it that we wanted to test.

376
00:58:29.380 --> 00:58:39.769
David Mermin: So, because of that, that came first, and that was sort of the centerpiece. Therefore, when people were responding on the sales tax, they did, in fact, have in their head

377
00:58:39.850 --> 00:58:52.200
David Mermin: the infrastructure, even though we said, alright, now just consider this separately. We know that they had heard the infrastructure measure first, and it's possible that affected their, you know, that their ordering effects are common, as you know, and.

378
00:58:52.200 --> 00:58:54.019
Boardroom: Yeah. And pending research.

379
00:58:54.400 --> 00:59:04.419
David Mermin: What we will do in a follow-up survey, what we recommend doing, is that we would take the things that we know to be on the ballot, or very likely to be on the ballot in the fall.

380
00:59:05.010 --> 00:59:12.260
David Mermin: That are revenue-related, and ask them in the order that they were… or, like, they're expected to appear on the actual ballot.

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381
00:59:12.260 --> 00:59:12.910
Boardroom: Okay.

382
00:59:12.910 --> 00:59:15.000
David Mermin: So that, we're simulating

383
00:59:15.560 --> 00:59:23.619
David Mermin: whatever it is, you know, as they go through their ballot, people say, okay, I've seen the state measure, and I've seen the housing bond, and I've seen the

384
00:59:24.490 --> 00:59:28.350
David Mermin: transportation, you know, the Bay Area Transportation, Rescue.

385
00:59:28.350 --> 00:59:29.370
Boardroom: And…

386
00:59:29.370 --> 00:59:41.449
David Mermin: the, you know, in the Alameda County, whatever they're doing, and now… and now I get to Berkeley, and then they'll have… they will have seen those other things in November when they come to vote, so we want to test it in that context.

387
00:59:41.450 --> 00:59:43.399
Boardroom: Got it. And likewise.

388
00:59:43.400 --> 00:59:47.599
David Mermin: If the city goes ahead with both of these, in whatever order.

389
00:59:48.220 --> 00:59:54.660
David Mermin: We can, you know, talk about how we would test that appropriately in this follow-up survey, but that's how we did it this time.

390
00:59:54.660 --> 00:59:59.280
Boardroom: So in this instrument, maybe there might have… the drag was there for the sales tax, like, they will… they'll…

391

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00:59:59.280 --> 01:00:15.410
David Mermin: If there was any drag from, like, oh, I'm hearing more taxes, it would have brought the sales tax down. Potentially, that, you know, that has a couple of points of fact. We don't… we don't… we didn't do an experiment to test, so we don't know, but it's plausible that there was a little drag on that.

392
01:00:15.410 --> 01:00:26.219
Boardroom: Okay. And then, just to follow up on Councilmember Trey Gibb's, questions, about the Civic Center buildings, again, I, I'm supportive of,

393
01:00:26.220 --> 01:00:44.579
Boardroom: investment there to, again, for the retrofit, for the rebuilding of that infrastructure, for the maintenance of that infrastructure, and kind of bringing those buildings back into… into use over time. And I know there was some commentary in the… in the more extended poll research about how to frame it. Could you just kind of characterize…

394
01:00:44.620 --> 01:00:53.959
Boardroom: You know, what's our strongest kind of argument around that, just as we're thinking about it, in terms of how people, you know, view that infrastructure?

395
01:00:54.760 --> 01:00:56.830
David Mermin: Stronger's argument for infrastructure.

396
01:00:56.830 --> 01:00:57.559
Boardroom: For that, for that.

397
01:00:57.560 --> 01:00:57.960
David Mermin: P.S.

398
01:00:57.960 --> 01:00:59.559
Boardroom: Civic Center pieces, like, because, again.

399
01:00:59.560 --> 01:01:03.780
David Mermin: Yeah, I think for Civic Center, it is… if you say…

400
01:01:04.150 --> 01:01:17.720
David Mermin: we're going to rebuild the buildings in the Civic Center. That is not… that does not appear to be the most exciting part of this

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for voters. It's not that they're against it, it's just that they don't rate it as hot, right, relatively speaking.

401
01:01:18.020 --> 01:01:28.490
David Mermin: When you say, we have a lot of buildings that need repairs in the city to be able to provide services that people need, and these include

402
01:01:28.790 --> 01:01:36.269
David Mermin: you know, senior centers, community centers, and the civic Center buildings in the downtown core, and for both

403
01:01:37.640 --> 01:01:50.320
David Mermin: you know, for quality of life and for safety, we need to make those improvements, that does better. And so that looks like the way to describe what means, you know, what could be invested in

404
01:01:50.740 --> 01:02:01.329
David Mermin: You know, and we're not offering any opinion here about how you would actually allocate, or what the, you know, the specific mix. That's obviously for the experts on the actual

405
01:02:01.890 --> 01:02:08.870
David Mermin: infrastructure to do, but in terms of how it would be framed or described to the voters, it does appear

406
01:02:09.160 --> 01:02:17.809
David Mermin: That sort of envelope around the Civic Center is a better way to say it than just, hey, we're gonna fix this particular set of buildings.

407
01:02:17.810 --> 01:02:19.860
Boardroom: Okay, thank you. Thanks, Madam Mayor.

408
01:02:20.160 --> 01:02:24.009
Boardroom: Thank you. Is it any cooler outside than it is inside?

409
01:02:24.210 --> 01:02:36.460
Boardroom: Does anyone know? Because I'd love to be able to open the doors so we don't pass out. It's very hot in here. Okay, so going on to Councilmember Humbert, thank you for your patience.

410

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01:02:37.340 --> 01:02:43.729
Mark Humbert: Thank you. Thank you, Madam Mayor, and I've really appreciated the questions that my fellow Council members

411
01:02:43.840 --> 01:02:50.549
Mark Humbert: have… have posed so far. I just have a couple, and… and this is for…

412
01:02:50.760 --> 01:02:53.709
Mark Humbert: Dave W. and Paul B,

413
01:02:53.890 --> 01:03:02.720
Mark Humbert: as opposed to Dave M. As we write the bond measure language, do we have a fair

414
01:03:02.900 --> 01:03:15.709
Mark Humbert: Degree of latitude to determine how locked in the city is on the amount of bond money that goes to each category of project, and or what specific projects are funded.

415
01:03:16.850 --> 01:03:20.639
Mark Humbert: What level of flexibility do we have in that regard?

416
01:03:21.840 --> 01:03:29.940
Boardroom: It's an important question, and I may ask for a little help from our city attorney here, too, but one of the things we've definitely talked about as staff is

417
01:03:29.980 --> 01:03:53.720
Boardroom: the need to have some level of flexibility built into this measure. We wanted… we do want to have these projects identified, but if, for example, one of the projects, the two that we were just talking about, Old City Hall and the Veterans Building, we've got a $16 million grant in to FEMA to do those projects. If we got that grant and we needed less money for this project, we would want to have the flexibility to transfer it over to another project. So.

418
01:03:53.720 --> 01:04:06.670
Boardroom: We do need to figure out a way to build in some flexibility so that we're not locked into projects in a way that constrain us from actually doing good work for the city. And obviously, we work closely with our city attorney colleagues to come up with what that…

419

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01:04:06.690 --> 01:04:25.870
Boardroom: Moonlight. And maybe, maybe Assistant City Attorney Harvey could help with that. Sure, so as a general matter, the bond measures are required to describe the purpose to which the funds will be used. In practice, the City will describe, you know, the types of projects that that will go to.

420
01:04:25.870 --> 01:04:34.590
Boardroom: So, you know, there was some flexibility, provided the ultimate use of the funds, you know, matches the description in the ballot, language.

421
01:04:34.900 --> 01:04:35.580
Boardroom: No.

422
01:04:37.300 --> 01:04:43.499
Mark Humbert: Yeah, thank you. I had a second question, but you've answered that as well. I appreciate it. That's all I have.

423
01:04:44.650 --> 01:04:47.210
Boardroom: Thank you very much. Councilmember Bartlett?

424
01:04:48.060 --> 01:04:51.730
Boardroom: Thank you, Madam Mayor. And, thank you, David and David.

425
01:04:51.870 --> 01:05:00.880
Boardroom: Three work, once again. One question. This goes to, I guess, the… David Berman, the pollster. The,

426
01:05:01.960 --> 01:05:07.059
Boardroom: So I, I, and you're a pro, I assume, I'm just wondering, I assume you controlled…

427
01:05:07.170 --> 01:05:13.189
Boardroom: For the… for the timing of the election, to… it's not a presidential year.

428
01:05:13.400 --> 01:05:18.010
Boardroom: So it obviously is a more conservative audience, right? I'm sure you control for that, right?

429
01:05:18.190 --> 01:05:36.809

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David Mermin: Yes, this is… that's an astute question, Councilmember, as you've looked at some polls in the past, and you're correct that, we want to simulate the likely electorate for this election year, so that is why this is not a survey of all adults or all citizens, or even all voters in the City of Berkeley. It is a survey of

430
01:05:36.850 --> 01:05:47.520
David Mermin: Those we expect to turn out and vote in a midterm general election 2026, based on their history, their vote history on the voter file.

431
01:05:47.890 --> 01:05:54.780
Boardroom: Okay, and that's why it explains some of the topics, right? The sidewalks, things, challenges faced by seniors, right? Sidewalks.

432
01:05:54.780 --> 01:06:08.119
David Mermin: It is a… it does skew a little older compared to the overall population of the city, yes, and when you… whenever you do a likely better survey, particularly in a somewhat lower turnout, then you're going to have more seniors relatively in the…

433
01:06:08.390 --> 01:06:09.570
David Mermin: Give your sample.

434
01:06:09.570 --> 01:06:10.810
Boardroom: Fire.

435
01:06:11.000 --> 01:06:14.449
Boardroom: Right, okay. And then, the other thing is,

436
01:06:14.550 --> 01:06:19.430
Boardroom: Oh yeah, this regarding, this is probably for everyone, you know,

437
01:06:19.790 --> 01:06:36.310
Boardroom: many times they challenge us about how we are gonna spend these things, right? And so our reputation is really good. The soda tax really got it going. I see some soda tax people here. And, you know, people didn't believe us that we would spend the money the way we said we would.

438
01:06:36.580 --> 01:06:46.570

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Boardroom: And because the threshold for the general fund is somewhat lower than specialized spending. And, so we form committees, and we actually follow through on what we promise in these measures.

439
01:06:46.570 --> 01:06:57.050
Boardroom: So it's really important that, as we design the language, and we form the committee afterwards, we honor our commitment, because that's our, that's our brand here. Our neighbors respect that, and they, and they expect it.

440
01:07:00.090 --> 01:07:01.659
Boardroom: Thank you,

441
01:07:02.090 --> 01:07:13.139
Boardroom: I'm gonna go back to Councilmember Trega. Is that your button? Yeah, thank you so much. I do have a couple more questions. One of them was,

442
01:07:13.310 --> 01:07:21.349
Boardroom: A follow-up to something Councilmember Blackaby asked, and, sorry, this is for…

443
01:07:22.530 --> 01:07:25.619
Boardroom: I don't know who it's for, actually.

444
01:07:26.100 --> 01:07:39.280
Boardroom: How, so, if I understood correctly, the second survey is going to model, the ballot more precisely to assess drag.

445
01:07:39.450 --> 01:07:52.650
Boardroom: But how can, the ballot be modeled in that way if it's not going to be clear at that time what all is going to be on the ballot and in which order?

446
01:07:54.360 --> 01:07:59.549
David Mermin: Well, I'll take all that from a survey design perspective, and then the staff may have other

447
01:07:59.710 --> 01:08:09.060
David Mermin: comments. I believe it's true we won't know exactly everything that will be on, but we will be much closer to knowing. We're talking about fielding, I believe, in the later part of April.

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448
01:08:09.460 --> 01:08:16.000
David Mermin: And as these things come online, and the different governmental, agencies,

449
01:08:16.979 --> 01:08:21.330
David Mermin: go through their process of getting these measures placed on the ballot, I think we will…

450
01:08:21.979 --> 01:08:31.439
David Mermin: assess it as closely as we can, what is anticipated, likely to be on it. We, you know, to the extent that there are things that could happen before the actual deadlines.

451
01:08:31.760 --> 01:08:40.799
David Mermin: that, you know, it's possible. We can't anticipate everything. At the same time, you… there's a timeline, of course, for the city.

452
01:08:41.260 --> 01:08:59.129
David Mermin: to place your measures on, and you need to get your data before making those final decisions, so that's the window we're shooting for, and we will endeavor to get the best estimate from those in the know as to what is likely to appear on that November ballot, so we can simulate it as closely as we can.

453
01:08:59.510 --> 01:09:07.449
Boardroom: Okay, thank you. And then, in terms of the order, would there be A-B testing to, you know.

454
01:09:07.450 --> 01:09:19.169
David Mermin: We could A-B test again, we should decide, you know, the drawback there is that your sample is cut in half, and if it turns out one version is passing, the other is not.

455
01:09:19.510 --> 01:09:26.780
David Mermin: You have a little less confidence, because the version that's passing, it's only half your sample, so, you know, your margin of error is a little higher.

456
01:09:27.100 --> 01:09:28.809
David Mermin: So that's the trade-off.

457

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01:09:29.160 --> 01:09:34.060
David Mermin: What we tried to do was that kind of experiment in this first survey.

458
01:09:34.350 --> 01:09:41.790
David Mermin: To figure out things like language, and what to prioritize, and what level of so…

459
01:09:41.979 --> 01:09:51.739
David Mermin: I think we would generally not do as much of that second time around, but it is… it is something… it is a tool we still have, and we could decide to do so.

460
01:09:52.880 --> 01:10:01.660
Boardroom: Okay, thank you, and my last question is, at least at this time, is

461
01:10:02.320 --> 01:10:07.740
Boardroom: For that second survey, I…

462
01:10:08.110 --> 01:10:20.840
Boardroom: Is there an opportunity to dig in more deeply into arguments that talk about the opportunity costs of not passing a ballot measure? For instance.

463
01:10:21.260 --> 01:10:34.739
Boardroom: The opportunity cost of not restoring, the Madel Shirec City Hall building, and continuing to pay $300K to $400K,

464
01:10:35.040 --> 01:10:44.840
Boardroom: to the… to be USD, I think, per year, and again, this might be too granular, but, will there be some consideration to…

465
01:10:44.900 --> 01:10:56.620
Boardroom: What, we might be losing, or if we don't pass it, and potential benefits on the flip side of, approving this measure.

466
01:10:57.870 --> 01:11:08.479
David Mermin: I will say that in the current version of the survey where we tested, I didn't go through all the language that was in these arguments head-to-head, but it's in the report.

467

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01:11:08.880 --> 01:11:14.609
David Mermin: We did, in fact, in the positive argument, the argument in favor of voting yes, test

468
01:11:14.840 --> 01:11:21.429
David Mermin: It was a sentence, or half a sentence, that basically said, if we don't, you know, not investing in these

469
01:11:22.420 --> 01:11:27.640
David Mermin: Fixes now means greater costs in the future because they continue to deteriorate.

470
01:11:28.060 --> 01:11:33.310
David Mermin: So that is a capsule version of that argument. We could test a longer version of it.

471
01:11:33.860 --> 01:11:43.730
David Mermin: There's going to be some… but we're going to have… the time is going to be tight on that second survey, assuming we go forward with it, given that we have to test multiple measures.

472
01:11:43.900 --> 01:11:45.940
David Mermin: To simulate the ballot, so…

473
01:11:46.100 --> 01:11:51.410
David Mermin: We'll have to decide, in terms of priority, if we want to take another bite at the arguments.

474
01:11:51.970 --> 01:11:53.440
David Mermin: And, and perhaps…

475
01:11:53.550 --> 01:12:03.629
David Mermin: You know, further language as you suggest, but that, again, is an option, and we'll have to decide on that within the limitations of the length and budget for the sooner.

476
01:12:03.900 --> 01:12:04.809
Boardroom: Thank you.

477
01:12:05.480 --> 01:12:12.899
Boardroom: Okay, thank you very much. I have two questions, and then I think… I think everyone else has asked their questions already.

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478
01:12:12.900 --> 01:12:34.260
Boardroom: Can you speak more to the strategy around refining the list? I'm concerned about losing some projects that would be important for equity, like South Berkeley Green Space, or in terms of long-term need, like the projects in the marina that will cost us much more if we don't address them, or, you know, even what has been mentioned earlier about Civic Center, buildings where we could be

479
01:12:34.260 --> 01:12:36.310
Boardroom: Utilizing a match.

480
01:12:37.190 --> 01:12:55.739
Boardroom: So I think, naturally, we want the input and feedback from Council, and there's not going to be… this will be part art, part science, right? So we are digesting the input we got from the survey, it's an important piece of data for us. As I mentioned, we're doing all this community engagement, and staff are taking in all that input and feedback.

481
01:12:55.960 --> 01:12:59.159
Boardroom: We're seeing the reports come from various commissions.

482
01:12:59.490 --> 01:13:14.220
Boardroom: And really importantly, we're going to be updating the costs associated with the, projects that have been identified, and thinking about, you know, what we need from a staffing perspective. So, we're gonna take all this in totality and try to develop

483
01:13:14.220 --> 01:13:17.729
Boardroom: The most robust list that we possibly can that ensures

484
01:13:17.730 --> 01:13:35.409
Boardroom: you know, we're addressing climate resiliency, that we're, you know, centered on equity, and thinking about, you know, how we respond from a public safety perspective. So, there are going to be hard choices, there's no doubt about it, but we're going to do our best to be as balanced as we possibly can in the list that we ultimately bring forward to the Council.

485
01:13:36.160 --> 01:13:49.060
Boardroom: Thank you, I really appreciate that. I think this is something that I struggle with politics in general, is that we use, polling results

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from people who are most likely voters, which means they're more likely to be more affluent.

486
01:13:49.060 --> 01:14:03.900
Boardroom: you know, have more resources generally, and so that also determines the projects that we do, inherently, so I just want to bring that up as we're talking about this. And, Ken, also, I would love…

487
01:14:04.130 --> 01:14:15.090
Boardroom: if we can also share with the public the relationship between Measure T1 and this bond when it comes to our residents' bills, because my understanding is that T1 is sunsetting, so what will that look like?

488
01:14:16.650 --> 01:14:26.259
Boardroom: So, I can, when we come back to you, I can bring forward a chart that was prepared by our financial advisor that helped to show, sort of, the perspective of

489
01:14:26.660 --> 01:14:31.259
Boardroom: Everything that we've issued in the past, and sort of what's,

490
01:14:31.970 --> 01:14:46.899
Boardroom: been paid off, and then what it looks like going forward, what this new measure would be with what's still, authorized to issue, or what's already existing. So, the number we gave you, about $22.14 per $100,000 of assessed value.

491
01:14:46.900 --> 01:15:03.809
Boardroom: That represents the new bond. When we look in totality and include existing authorizations, don't quote me specifically, but the total assessment rate would be, on average, about $44 per $100,000, and I can be more precise when we come back to the Council, but that was about the number.

492
01:15:05.300 --> 01:15:18.529
Boardroom: Okay, that's great. I think we just want to make sure folks understand what, at the end of the day, their bills will look like. I think that'll be important to our residents, so… although, it's great to see so much support, so… Okay, yeah. And I would just add, what was…

493
01:15:18.530 --> 01:15:26.970
Boardroom: Just to kind of amplify, what was important about, those numbers is that when we looked over a longer period of time, going back to about 1993,

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494
01:15:26.970 --> 01:15:33.320
Boardroom: We were well below, the peak assessment value of when we've issued bonds in the past.

495
01:15:33.320 --> 01:15:48.319
Boardroom: And well within the average. So it was nice to see that because of the growth in our assessed value, we're able to work within a responsible, threshold. We're not reaching the peak, we're certainly not at the lowest point, but we're within a decent range.

496
01:15:48.710 --> 01:16:07.200
Boardroom: Totally, and I remember looking at those graphs as well, and I still know that folks are really sensitive to affordability right now. It's an important issue for a lot of people that I'm speaking with, so just want us to be conscious of it. Okay, very good. Well, let's move on to the public comment then, please.

497
01:16:07.450 --> 01:16:11.990
Boardroom: Is there any public comment for this item? And please just come up…

498
01:16:12.130 --> 01:16:15.109
Boardroom: To the podium up here, I see some hands raised.

499
01:16:24.400 --> 01:16:27.130
Boardroom: Any order is fine. Yep.

500
01:16:30.580 --> 01:16:33.420
Boardroom: Good evening, I'm Dr. Steven Alpert.

501
01:16:33.670 --> 01:16:35.959
Boardroom: Resident of, District 5.

502
01:16:36.470 --> 01:16:52.160
Boardroom: Citizens applaud the city doing these surveys to test the waters of the voters, but 500 is 1% of the 50,000 collective votes for mayor in 2024. It's an inadequate sample size to generate any meaningful data.

503
01:16:52.310 --> 01:16:54.480
Boardroom: Entire survey should be discarded.

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504
01:16:59.340 --> 01:17:11.789
Boardroom: Thank you. I'm Dr. Celeste Marks back again, and I'm going to say exactly the same thing. Your sample is way too small to draw meaningful conclusions. We want results.

505
01:17:11.850 --> 01:17:20.310
Boardroom: that reflect the attitudes and the demographics balanced. It may be a randomized study, you know, so that…

506
01:17:21.120 --> 01:17:25.709
Boardroom: Added a little character, but mostly increases sample size.

507
01:17:26.690 --> 01:17:27.580
Boardroom: Thank you.

508
01:17:31.390 --> 01:17:34.830
Boardroom: Hi, I'm Gordon Wozniak, I was formerly in the Council.

509
01:17:35.070 --> 01:17:37.949
Boardroom: I want to thank staff. I think it was an excellent report.

510
01:17:38.170 --> 01:17:41.130
Boardroom: I want to maybe amplify a couple of things.

511
01:17:41.680 --> 01:17:51.519
Boardroom: there's a context I think you have to be a little worried about, is taxes have been going up, mainly because of parcel tax, not due to the debt service tax. In fact.

512
01:17:51.810 --> 01:17:59.279
Boardroom: As, David said, over the last 30 years, the debt service tax has gone down by 50%, okay?

513
01:17:59.510 --> 01:18:09.620
Boardroom: And so it's not what's really driving people's taxes. The other thing I think you have to have in a context, which I don't know if you can deal with this in our survey, or this is campaign literature.

514
01:18:10.010 --> 01:18:27.949

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Boardroom: Berkeley only gets about a third of the ad valorem taxes, and it only gets about 40% of the parcel taxes. There are a lot of other entities that cause your taxes to go up, and yet, because it's listed as Berkeley property taxes, everybody thinks the city gets it all, which is nonsense, okay? It's just not correct.

515
01:18:28.420 --> 01:18:46.880
Boardroom: And the other thing that I think is a powerful selling point, which is mentioned in T1, is leverage. If you can get grant leverage existing money, you want to make that a good selling point. Sorry, Gordon. We're gonna, you know, there's someone giving you a minute, so you can finish your point if you want. The last thing I think is what's really unique

516
01:18:47.030 --> 01:18:54.290
Boardroom: about the T1 bond measures is that the city's been very good at leveraging that tax dollars.

517
01:18:54.640 --> 01:18:59.849
Boardroom: You want a hammer on that, because that's… even conservative Republicans should appreciate that.

518
01:19:00.220 --> 01:19:09.999
Boardroom: So, I think there's a lot of good things, there are a lot of good stories, and you should tell them, not just focus on the dry stuff of, what buildings are gonna get built and stuff like that.

519
01:19:11.900 --> 01:19:14.229
Boardroom: Thank you, and thank you to the Vice Mayor.

520
01:19:15.890 --> 01:19:22.940
Boardroom: Hello, I'm Linda Alberti, I live, feel free to adjust your mic so we can hear you better. Is that better?

521
01:19:23.390 --> 01:19:26.710
Boardroom: I live by Nilsen and Gilman Streets,

522
01:19:26.930 --> 01:19:42.330
Boardroom: And I was concerned about the in-sampling of the survey. I thought it was too small. And then another thing I'm concerned about, is, like, sidewalk safety and things like that. My neighbors got together, we ended up just doing our sidewalks and having to pay for all of it ourselves.

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523
01:19:42.330 --> 01:20:01.689
Boardroom: Because a wait list to get something through the city was ridiculously long. I don't know if we can do Adopt the Sidewalk program. We have elders going up and down the streets, and they're just not safe. I worry about falls, and also I worry about, mindfulness with spending our money, like the Hopkins Corridor. I don't know how much money was wasted on that.

524
01:20:01.990 --> 01:20:10.129
Boardroom: down by Monterey Market and all that, with the bike lanes, I'm hoping that they can be more mindful with how the money gets spent for future projects.

525
01:20:10.910 --> 01:20:17.029
Boardroom: That's it. Thank you, and I do appreciate you. I've noticed a positive change under your leadership, so thank you.

526
01:20:17.230 --> 01:20:18.360
Boardroom: Thank you.

527
01:20:18.790 --> 01:20:19.929
Boardroom: Thanks for your comment.

528
01:20:25.470 --> 01:20:31.499
Boardroom: Aye, so I believe that Carol… Will give me another minute.

529
01:20:31.880 --> 01:20:33.060
Boardroom: Thank you.

530
01:20:33.330 --> 01:20:35.349
Boardroom: Am I close enough to the mic?

531
01:20:37.100 --> 01:20:45.890
Boardroom: It's okay? Am I close enough? Yeah, I would prefer if someone could… yeah, that would be great. Even that, I think. Better? Yeah, thanks. Alright.

532
01:20:47.120 --> 01:21:04.199
Boardroom: Good evening, Mayor and Council Members. I'm speaking on behalf of the Commission on Disability, and to the City's request for feedback on priorities and gaps in the bond measure. It's clear that Berkeley's infrastructure needs are significantly underfunded.

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533
01:21:05.010 --> 01:21:06.209
Boardroom: I'm gonna skip.

534
01:21:06.360 --> 01:21:17.640
Boardroom: Right now, our central concern is the structure, the structure of the proposed bond. Accessibility is at risk of being fully acknowledged in principle.

535
01:21:17.870 --> 01:21:30.359
Boardroom: but underfunded in practice. In the proposed funding structure, accessibility appears inside the broad category that addresses critical infrastructure

536
01:21:30.730 --> 01:21:35.050
Boardroom: and accessibility. That $100 million pot

537
01:21:35.510 --> 01:21:45.829
Boardroom: of money, the red pot, includes proposed major seismic upgrades to the three Civic Center buildings. You put a shovel near

538
01:21:45.980 --> 01:22:01.280
Boardroom: a foundation, and you really don't know what the cost of the project is. In addition, that same pot of money includes modernization of the three civic buildings. Again, very, very costly projects.

539
01:22:01.290 --> 01:22:19.560
Boardroom: capital improvements, that the sidewalks and the list of accessibility projects, which includes removing trip hazards, improving the sidewalks, funding the 50-50 program, fixing crosswalks, have to compete against.

540
01:22:19.560 --> 01:22:32.820
Boardroom: At the same time, that priority was in a statistical tie with funding fire safety. It's what people all across the city want. So don't have it compete

541
01:22:32.850 --> 01:22:36.800
Boardroom: With these intensely expensive structural

542
01:22:37.080 --> 01:22:48.700

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Boardroom: projects have a set-aside pot of money within the $100 million, a percentage that guarantees addressing these critical improvements.

543
01:22:48.850 --> 01:22:50.650
Boardroom: Thank you. Thank you.

544
01:22:51.800 --> 01:22:53.440
Boardroom: Thanks for your comment.

545
01:22:53.820 --> 01:22:57.529
Boardroom: I love the enthusiasm from the audience, too.

546
01:23:02.400 --> 01:23:16.929
Boardroom: Hi, I just wanted to thank the City Council for making hard decisions in order to provide the services that Berkeley needs, but I wanted to specifically highlight, the fact that

547
01:23:17.080 --> 01:23:22.850
Boardroom: the… The 0.5% sales tax is… It's…

548
01:23:22.990 --> 01:23:35.580
Boardroom: It's very regressive. I'm sure you all know this, and 0.5% seems like a small amount, and it seems like it's just gonna bring us in line with the nearest cities, but that has a real impact on people living in the city.

549
01:23:35.580 --> 01:23:51.329
Boardroom: And I was encouraged to hear talk earlier of potentially looking at an increase in the value of the bond measure. I hope you will consider in the future, using methods that are less aggressive in order to raise funds. Thank you.

550
01:23:52.080 --> 01:23:53.240
Boardroom: Thank you.

551
01:23:58.260 --> 01:24:13.459
Boardroom: Hello, I'm Ronnie Hancock. Like Gordon, I was a council member once. I know the choices are hard. I do want to speak very strongly tonight, though, in favor of the whole city project.

552
01:24:13.580 --> 01:24:18.469

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Boardroom: which is the downtown and the Civic Center.

553
01:24:19.280 --> 01:24:29.609
Boardroom: These buildings, especially the buildings in the Civic Center, are important, historic, owned infrastructure by the city.

554
01:24:29.750 --> 01:24:33.470
Boardroom: They have history, and they have architectural merit.

555
01:24:33.640 --> 01:24:41.969
Boardroom: They anchor that whole part of the community. We have the educational testing building, we have

556
01:24:42.850 --> 01:24:46.579
Boardroom: you know, 2180 Millville, we have the beautiful

557
01:24:46.780 --> 01:24:52.839
Boardroom: beautifully refurbished high school. We need to have

558
01:24:52.950 --> 01:25:00.239
Boardroom: this, it all put together. We can bring back city offices, as was explained.

559
01:25:00.530 --> 01:25:01.870
Boardroom: Thank you.

560
01:25:03.890 --> 01:25:11.689
Boardroom: Does anyone want to give her a minute? Oh, you're giving… you're giving… you're being given a minute. Yes, if you want to continue.

561
01:25:11.910 --> 01:25:14.810
Boardroom: We have to get the seismic…

562
01:25:15.130 --> 01:25:30.049
Boardroom: upgrade done, and I really thank the city manager and staff for the FEMA application, and there may be other things we could go after as well. But we would save money if we bought the city buildings back, and many of us

563
01:25:30.240 --> 01:25:39.399

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Boardroom: really love what the Berkeley Historical Society has done, and would love to see a permanent place for that. Other cities have done this.

564
01:25:39.560 --> 01:25:44.279
Boardroom: San Francisco, when its city hall was upgraded. Pasadena.

565
01:25:44.490 --> 01:25:55.750
Boardroom: Even Jerry Brout, in his first administration, upgraded the vacant state capitol, which was unusable because of seismic issues.

566
01:25:55.930 --> 01:25:56.920
Boardroom: So…

567
01:25:57.400 --> 01:26:07.300
Boardroom: we, I think, can do this and would be very proud of it for generations. It's, somebody said to me today there.

568
01:26:07.460 --> 01:26:16.660
Boardroom: One of the few things a society produces that survive from generation to generation is art. Thank you.

569
01:26:21.000 --> 01:26:36.660
Boardroom: We have all of the… it feels like all the previous mayors here, almost. It's just tough following the former mayor, you know. You know, she was the first woman elected mayor of Berkeley. So, anyway, yes, that kind of thought.

570
01:26:36.660 --> 01:26:41.950
Boardroom: So anyway, you guys, I want to say, first of all, I'm very impressed with the process you're going through.

571
01:26:41.950 --> 01:27:00.490
Boardroom: I'm really the staff, you know, and what they're doing, and how you're analyzing this, and how you're looking at this. I think it's absolutely right, the right direction, and I really want to encourage you. One of the things that worries me a little bit is the fact that you're going to do a second poll, and I really, really want to see you do a second poll, but I don't know if it's going to be enough.

572
01:27:00.490 --> 01:27:16.070
Boardroom: I think you might even consider, believe it or not, doing two more polls. You know, one more to try to figure out exactly what you

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think you would shape it into it, and, you know, what should be in that $300 million. And then, I think you need to focus on the arguments.

573
01:27:16.070 --> 01:27:30.850
Boardroom: Because I think how you present your arguments is going to be essential. Now, if you can do it in one poll, great. Then I want you to know, I'm gonna say, I don't want you to spend money just to be spending money. But I think it's very important, the messaging and how we present it.

574
01:27:30.850 --> 01:27:42.970
Boardroom: Because this community is so, so wonderful and so rich, and will reach out and fund things and do things if they believe it's in the right interest. So… Thank you. You're very welcome. Thank you very much.

575
01:27:47.960 --> 01:27:58.600
Boardroom: Hi, I'm Ann Harlow, president of the Berkeley Historical Society and Museum, currently occupying part of the Veterans Building and slated to occupy part of the Old City Hall.

576
01:27:59.380 --> 01:28:08.149
Boardroom: Waddleshuric Building. We, the museum, have spent… have made a lot of progress in becoming more recognized and appreciated in the community.

577
01:28:08.290 --> 01:28:12.320
Boardroom: Partly with the help of some of you.

578
01:28:12.720 --> 01:28:26.940
Boardroom: But it's, rather embarrassing when someone actually visits and sees the condition the building's in, and if they notice that it's got a sign that says, you know, this building is seismically unsafe.

579
01:28:28.530 --> 01:28:36.269
Boardroom: It falls under both the, community facility and quality of life category, and the critical infrastructure and safety.

580
01:28:36.590 --> 01:28:40.780
Boardroom: let's see, so what?

581
01:28:41.030 --> 01:28:43.839
Boardroom: I'd really like to see you,

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582
01:28:44.040 --> 01:28:46.439
Boardroom: Allocate enough money so that the

583
01:28:46.610 --> 01:28:49.530
Boardroom: City Hall project can be completed.

584
01:28:50.560 --> 01:29:05.599
Boardroom: Thank you. Oh, someone is giving you a minute. Okay. Yeah, yeah, so I suggest $325 million. It's exactly half of the $650 that failed a few years ago, and there's been inflation.

585
01:29:05.600 --> 01:29:12.620
Boardroom: Also in April 2028 will be the 100… Berkeley's 150th birthday, and if you could somehow,

586
01:29:12.660 --> 01:29:14.040
Boardroom: Make it happen that…

587
01:29:14.120 --> 01:29:31.969
Boardroom: there's at least, you know, enough progress that there could be some sort of ceremonial, this is going to be what this building is going to be in another few years, including the council will be meeting back here again, there will be all these other meeting spaces for, other groups, and, I'm hoping that

588
01:29:32.100 --> 01:29:38.040
Boardroom: so-called council chambers could be a multi-use room. I'm thinking, well, maybe if you need your dais, there could be a…

589
01:29:38.370 --> 01:29:39.940
Boardroom: A partition of some sort.

590
01:29:40.790 --> 01:29:43.790
Boardroom: I think I'm out of time. I like the idea. Thank you.

591
01:29:47.740 --> 01:30:08.549
Boardroom: Good evening, City Council. David Flores here, District 2 resident and, Executive Director of Berkeley Community Media. I just want to say a great job with the, the survey that the staff did. I went to two of the events, and they provided a lot of time for folks to ask questions and get information, but I just want to echo what some of the stuff, I've been hearing here, too, of just, you know, if…

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592
01:30:08.550 --> 01:30:23.210
Boardroom: we could just get at least the seismic retrofit on some of these old buildings, just because the longer we leave it, the more expensive it's gonna get. And, you know, the price of that compared to some of the other projects that I saw on there is significantly less, so…

593
01:30:23.210 --> 01:30:25.710
Boardroom: In my opinion, would be a little more doable, but…

594
01:30:26.510 --> 01:30:46.369
Boardroom: Honestly, I get that it's gonna be in conflict with some of these other stuff. So, it's a big decision you guys have to make. I appreciate y'all taking the time and listening to all of us and taking community input, and I really do believe in the vision of a revitalized civic Center. I could see a really beautiful, you know, spending the whole afternoon in the downtown area.

595
01:30:46.370 --> 01:30:52.259
Boardroom: For restaurants, and then events, and community engagement. So, thank you. Thank you.

596
01:30:53.740 --> 01:30:59.480
Boardroom: Okay, is there any public comment online for our item?

597
01:30:59.710 --> 01:31:09.689
Boardroom: I think there's lots. Yes. Currently have 11 hands raised. The first commenter is Chad. Chad, you should be able to speak.

598
01:31:30.890 --> 01:31:31.450
Chad Chesterwizzle: Yeah.

599
01:31:31.450 --> 01:31:34.259
Boardroom: Oh, no, you're… you're echoing, Chad.

600
01:31:34.260 --> 01:31:36.869
Chad Chesterwizzle: Yeah, so I was just.

601
01:31:36.870 --> 01:31:40.380
Boardroom: Is there someone nearby that has the meeting open?

602

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01:31:41.320 --> 01:31:43.419
Chad Chesterwizzle: Is that any better? Is that any better?

603
01:31:43.420 --> 01:31:45.100
Boardroom: Much better, great.

604
01:31:47.100 --> 01:31:49.900
Chad Chesterwizzle: So what I wanted to talk about was,

605
01:31:50.790 --> 01:31:56.399
Chad Chesterwizzle: I am totally against all this polling. I think there's too much of it, it's going too in-depth.

606
01:31:59.580 --> 01:32:06.670
Chad Chesterwizzle: There was time… I used to go down. I liked the, public…

607
01:32:06.980 --> 01:32:11.179
Chad Chesterwizzle: And I would go down to the harbor, and I would just watch the sea lions.

608
01:32:11.800 --> 01:32:15.909
Chad Chesterwizzle: And, I remember one time there was an unhoused group of…

609
01:32:20.450 --> 01:32:25.230
Chad Chesterwizzle: I, my friends.

610
01:32:25.940 --> 01:32:29.459
Chad Chesterwizzle: And, it wasn't a good situation at all.

611
01:32:30.380 --> 01:32:33.540
Chad Chesterwizzle: They're, beach-going.

612
01:32:36.890 --> 01:32:44.259
Boardroom: Chad, you're cutting in and out very badly. If you want to call back later, we can try to let you comment then.

613
01:32:45.710 --> 01:32:52.499
Boardroom: Or with a different device or something. Next is… Wandi?

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614
01:32:52.780 --> 01:32:55.040
Boardroom: Wandi should be able to speak.

615
01:33:08.650 --> 01:33:13.050
Boardroom: I see you're unmuted. Wanda, you should be able to… Provide comments.

616
01:33:17.230 --> 01:33:18.389
Wandy Stig: Next step.

617
01:33:20.960 --> 01:33:22.070
Boardroom: I want these.

618
01:33:22.730 --> 01:33:24.619
Boardroom: Bad connection.

619
01:33:25.110 --> 01:33:33.800
Boardroom: I'm so sorry. For some reason, our second public commenter also was, we couldn't understand what they were saying.

620
01:33:34.140 --> 01:33:41.169
Boardroom: I'm hoping this is not a tech issue, and maybe they're together in the same room or something. Possibly. Let's try David Scheer.

621
01:33:46.380 --> 01:33:56.619
David Shere: Hi. I was very pleasantly surprised to see the right track, wrong track numbers on this survey. There can be a lot of negativity

622
01:33:56.620 --> 01:34:02.650
David Shere: In our, public… in our public discourse, and so often the most negative voices

623
01:34:02.650 --> 01:34:21.130
David Shere: are the loudest voices. The comment… the public comments that we usually get are overwhelmingly not tenants, not students, not young parents. So this survey, which is a scientific survey, you know, they do the whole country, it's… they do 1,500 people, I think… I hope that this shows where the voters in the city actually are.

624
01:34:21.130 --> 01:34:23.649
David Shere: And I hope that you keep

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625
01:34:23.670 --> 01:34:43.160
David Shere: that you keep this in mind when you're getting yelled at about corridor up zoning, or street safety, or any of the many other things that people like to yell at you about. The loudest voices in the community are not the same thing as the community. They don't represent the community. You guys and the people who put you into office represent the community.

626
01:34:43.430 --> 01:34:44.770
David Shere: That's all I got. Thank you.

627
01:34:45.600 --> 01:34:46.990
Boardroom: Thank you, David.

628
01:34:48.010 --> 01:34:53.260
Boardroom: Next is… Hiram?

629
01:34:58.500 --> 01:34:59.340
Hiram Blatt: Hello?

630
01:35:00.100 --> 01:35:01.330
Boardroom: Yes, go ahead.

631
01:35:02.070 --> 01:35:11.370
Hiram Blatt: How are you? Yes, I was just wanting to say that I agree with the gentleman in the green shirt who commented earlier that we should have more polls.

632
01:35:13.010 --> 01:35:19.000
Hiram Blatt: I'm a big proponent of, putting on as many poles as we possibly can.

633
01:35:19.000 --> 01:35:21.480
Boardroom: St. Patrick's Day!

634
01:35:25.010 --> 01:35:36.099
Boardroom: Thank you. Everyone's laughing because it's St. Patrick's Day, so a lot of us are wearing green shirts right now. Thank you. I think he meant former Mayor Bates, right?

635

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01:35:36.680 --> 01:35:42.050
Boardroom: Okay, next is a caller with a phone number ending in 405.

636
01:35:45.880 --> 01:36:10.200
1510****405: Two questions. Who's gonna perform an audit on a billion-dollar event? Certainly an opportunity for shaky hands. Second, in the polling question, was a question asked, how do you feel about, incurring a debt of $20,000 per household?

637
01:36:10.200 --> 01:36:16.299
1510****405: Or more than $5,000 of debt per man, woman, and child.

638
01:36:21.160 --> 01:36:24.399
Boardroom: Thank you. Okay, thank you for your comments.

639
01:36:24.630 --> 01:36:31.839
Boardroom: Next is, charlie? Charlie should be able to unmute.

640
01:36:34.960 --> 01:36:38.169
Charlie Cunningham: ride around, we throw that to the side.

641
01:36:38.410 --> 01:36:44.879
Boardroom: Okay. Alright. We are getting some interesting public comment today. Next is Corey.

642
01:36:45.040 --> 01:36:47.310
Boardroom: Corey, you should be able to speak.

643
01:36:51.590 --> 01:36:53.020
Corey Busay: Yes, can you hear me?

644
01:36:53.210 --> 01:36:54.620
Boardroom: Yes, yes, we can.

645
01:36:55.090 --> 01:37:02.789
Corey Busay: Great, thanks very much for the work done so far, very much appreciate it. I noticed that the survey was only looking at

646
01:37:02.850 --> 01:37:18.920
Corey Busay: tax on assessed value, and not on square footage of parcels. As a resident who just bought a house in Berkeley a few years ago,

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several of my neighbors have property tax bills that are 20% of what I pay.

647
01:37:18.950 --> 01:37:22.970
Corey Busay: And so, from an equity perspective, it would be ideal

648
01:37:23.230 --> 01:37:36.999
Corey Busay: to consider looking at taxes from a square footage as opposed to an assessed value perspective, so that we can make sure that every homeowner in Berkeley pays their fair share for this tax. Thanks for your consideration.

649
01:37:38.560 --> 01:37:42.300
Boardroom: Okay, thank you. Next is Kelly Hammergren.

650
01:37:46.460 --> 01:37:52.710
kelly hammargren: So, looking at the survey results, can you hear me okay?

651
01:37:53.150 --> 01:37:54.430
Boardroom: Yep, we can hear you.

652
01:37:54.430 --> 01:37:55.230
kelly hammargren: Okay.

653
01:37:55.330 --> 01:38:00.619
kelly hammargren: I'd say the city benefits from short memories and not paying attention.

654
01:38:00.800 --> 01:38:09.239
kelly hammargren: I've been looking over my property tax bill, and much of the stuff in the list we are already paying for through special taxes.

655
01:38:09.670 --> 01:38:11.570
kelly hammargren: On…

656
01:38:12.110 --> 01:38:26.709
kelly hammargren: Berkeley has a higher ratio of employees to residents than any other city I checked in the Bay Area and up and down the state, and we still pay… drop a considerable amount of money on consultants.

657

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01:38:27.140 --> 01:38:41.069
kelly hammargren: I'd like to know how the sidewalk funding in this bond measure, proposed bond measure, is supposed to line up with Measure FF for streets. There should be around $14 million available for sidewalks.

658
01:38:41.430 --> 01:38:46.600
kelly hammargren: And please note that the Oversight Committee for FF has only met twice.

659
01:38:47.050 --> 01:38:51.529
kelly hammargren: And the last meeting was canceled, and on the 24th is.

660
01:38:51.530 --> 01:38:54.400
Boardroom: Thanks, Kelly. Thank you. Thanks for your public comment.

661
01:38:54.630 --> 01:38:56.929
Boardroom: Next is Arlene.

662
01:38:57.100 --> 01:38:59.860
Boardroom: Arlene, you should be able to unmute.

663
01:39:08.560 --> 01:39:09.680
Boardroom: Arlene?

664
01:39:12.190 --> 01:39:13.880
Arlene Silk (2): I'm…

665
01:39:14.270 --> 01:39:34.529
Arlene Silk (2): I'm speaking to urge you to include the… include the money for the bond measure for the retrofit of Old City Hall and the Veterans Building. You know, our City Hall was built in 1909, and our city… the city then spent the money on the same architects that built San Francisco City Hall, which is beautifully restored. And not only could we save money.

666
01:39:34.610 --> 01:39:46.549
Arlene Silk (2): by not having to rent the school district property, but we could use it for events, and… and I… the old city hall is as much a symbol of Berkeley as the Campanile is for the university.

667
01:39:47.910 --> 01:39:54.669

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Arlene Silk (2): The Downtown Berkeley Association has been working on this for 6 years now, to restore the civic centers.

668
01:39:56.040 --> 01:39:56.940
Arlene Silk (2): Thank you.

669
01:39:57.930 --> 01:40:02.560
Boardroom: Thank you. Thank you, Arlene. I do want us to take, like, a very brief

670
01:40:02.800 --> 01:40:11.320
Boardroom: like, 10-minute stretch break. Okay. So we will… folks who are online, please hold. We will be back in 10. Thank you.

671
01:40:15.890 --> 01:40:31.639
Boardroom: Alright, thank you so much, everyone, for your patience. That was a very long 10 minutes, I know. But we are coming back to our online public comment, so I'm… thank you so much…

672
01:40:32.000 --> 01:40:38.890
Boardroom: for everyone who has spoken so far, and I will have our city clerk, help me out with this.

673
01:40:39.600 --> 01:40:41.960
Boardroom: Next up is Carolyn.

674
01:40:42.090 --> 01:40:44.109
Boardroom: Carolyn, you should be able to unmute.

675
01:40:45.240 --> 01:40:46.490
Carolyn McNiven: Hello, can you hear me?

676
01:40:46.690 --> 01:40:47.690
Boardroom: Yes.

677
01:40:48.030 --> 01:40:58.049
Carolyn McNiven: Thank you. I am a… I am a resident of Councilmember Blackaby's district. I agree 100% with Lonnie and Harlow and Arlene Silk.

678
01:40:58.050 --> 01:41:13.709

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Carolyn McNiven: those buildings should be preserved. Second, any further survey should be defensible based on a statistical sample blessed by a qualified statistician whose name and qualifications are made public.

679
01:41:13.930 --> 01:41:20.300
Carolyn McNiven: Doing anything less than that makes this whole process lack legitimacy.

680
01:41:20.470 --> 01:41:30.700
Carolyn McNiven: I note there's no margin for error that's been reported, and any decisions made based on a sample that was not statistically valid is indefensible.

681
01:41:31.250 --> 01:41:40.200
Carolyn McNiven: Thirdly, a city manager unprepared to explain, much less defend, the amount of a bond measure is simply astonishing.

682
01:41:40.310 --> 01:41:50.069
Carolyn McNiven: We need much better from our public servants. I mean, you should be asking for economic modeling for the various bond measure amounts.

683
01:41:50.420 --> 01:41:54.890
Boardroom: Thank you. Thanks, Carolyn. Next up is Christine.

684
01:41:57.510 --> 01:42:22.340
Christine U: Hi, so my name is Christine Uren. I live really near Civic Center Park, so I walk by it quite often. And I just want to say that I think that the Veterans Building and the Old City Hall are just beautiful buildings to look at. I really enjoy seeing them and walking by them, so I hope that they can be restored and made seismically safe and used. And I also think the Berkeley Historical Society does some really great, important work

685
01:42:22.630 --> 01:42:44.639
Christine U: for us learning about our past and fighting white supremacy, really. I mean, I found out a lot about the history of different groups in Berkeley and just in the Bay Area that I didn't know, and also just, you know, small but important stories about our history, and I hope we can… we can keep that going and preserve these buildings and help the society.

686
01:42:45.940 --> 01:42:48.789
Boardroom: Thank you, Christina. Thanks.

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687
01:42:49.270 --> 01:42:52.420
Boardroom: Next is Isaac.

688
01:42:56.380 --> 01:43:06.729
Isaac Warshauer: Good evening, Council. My name is Isaac Borschauer, I'm a resident of District 8, and I'm on the board of directors for the Berkeley Architectural Heritage Association.

689
01:43:06.940 --> 01:43:26.840
Isaac Warshauer: I'm also a parent of a 3-year-old Berkeleyan and a Berkeleyan expected in about 2 months. And I just wanted to speak about the value of restoring a civic Center and retrofitting the old City Hall Model Shirerich Building and Veterans Memorial Building.

690
01:43:26.970 --> 01:43:32.779
Isaac Warshauer: Now is an opportunity to continue with the planning and the implementation.

691
01:43:32.880 --> 01:43:43.439
Isaac Warshauer: of these projects, and if we wait too long, it may become too late, and it'll only be more expensive, and we should do this, for the coming generations. These buildings are irreplaceable.

692
01:43:43.440 --> 01:43:54.479
Isaac Warshauer: The Civic Center itself is the beating heart of Berkeley and an irreplaceable place, and we should do the best to make sure it remains there, for my children and for the children of everyone else in Berkeley.

693
01:43:54.500 --> 01:43:56.400
Isaac Warshauer: Thank you.

694
01:43:56.540 --> 01:44:00.139
Boardroom: Thank you, Isaac, and congratulations to your family.

695
01:44:00.690 --> 01:44:02.349
Boardroom: Next is Tony.

696
01:44:05.600 --> 01:44:18.200

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Toni: Good evening. When we talk about infrastructure, we have to remember that Mr. Terrence Davis, who is our current Director of Public Works, is leaving us on Friday.

697
01:44:18.430 --> 01:44:36.080
Toni: Which gives us no permanent director of public works as leadership for an infrastructure bond. This is a terrible thing. We have burned through 5 public works directors in the last 15 years, and we have to look hard at why we're doing this.

698
01:44:36.080 --> 01:44:39.790
Toni: And, you know, what we expect of these folks.

699
01:44:39.810 --> 01:45:03.499
Toni: We need a chief engineer very badly. We have a drainage plan, and nobody is talking about funding the drainage plan. A flood is a terrible thing. It can wipe out floods in the future, can wipe out private property all the way up to Sacramento Street in one fell swoop, and so we can no longer depend on gravity to drain the city of Berkeley.

700
01:45:03.500 --> 01:45:05.660
Toni: We are going to have to build

701
01:45:05.800 --> 01:45:11.900
Toni: Pumps, drainage pumps, one on the potted drain, and one on the strawberry drain.

702
01:45:12.920 --> 01:45:15.109
Boardroom: Next is Jeff Lomax.

703
01:45:17.780 --> 01:45:33.669
Geoff Lomax - KK6IZS: To the City Council Class of 2024, between new parcel taxes most of you endorsed that year, between the 6.4% 2025 parcel tax increase, you unanimously approved on consent with no compelling explanation.

704
01:45:33.830 --> 01:45:58.420
Geoff Lomax - KK6IZS: Between the new 2026 parcel taxes some of you have endorsed, and between this $700 million in total borrowing you are proposing now, you are on track for a 25% increase in property taxes for the average home in Berkeley over your 4-year term. Congratulations, you are on record-setting territory for unaffordability.

705

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01:46:01.570 --> 01:46:04.850
Boardroom: Thanks, Jeff. Next is… Mark?

706
01:46:06.530 --> 01:46:08.280
Boardroom: You should be able to unmute.

707
01:46:11.910 --> 01:46:13.360
Mark Beef: Jay, can you hear me?

708
01:46:15.690 --> 01:46:17.089
Boardroom: Do you have a comment regarding the…

709
01:46:17.190 --> 01:46:18.849
Mark Beef: for ballot measure polling.

710
01:46:19.640 --> 01:46:25.680
Mark Beef: I just wanted to say that this meeting has been going on too long, man. You guys think you're gonna, like, shut it down soon?

711
01:46:26.140 --> 01:46:28.890
Mark Beef: I got to go to bed, man, my kids are bothering me.

712
01:46:30.740 --> 01:46:32.470
Boardroom: Thank you for your comments.

713
01:46:32.640 --> 01:46:35.650
Boardroom: Next is Layla.

714
01:46:42.630 --> 01:46:43.300
Leila: Early.

715
01:46:44.610 --> 01:46:54.560
Leila: You are on track for a 25% increase in property taxes for the average home in Berkeley over your 4-year term.

716
01:46:54.700 --> 01:46:57.670
Boardroom: Hello? Oh. Oh. Okay.

717
01:46:59.270 --> 01:47:03.709
Boardroom: She's listening to the streaming that's behind.

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718
01:47:05.960 --> 01:47:08.350
Boardroom: Layla, turn off your web stream, and…

719
01:47:08.350 --> 01:47:09.379
Leila: Be able to unmute.

720
01:47:12.090 --> 01:47:14.540
Leila: Good evening, can you hear me? Yes.

721
01:47:14.540 --> 01:47:15.110
Boardroom: Oh.

722
01:47:15.550 --> 01:47:20.389
Leila: My voice got changed, that's alright. Do you have a comment when it comes to ballot measure polling?

723
01:47:20.710 --> 01:47:23.720
Leila: Yes.

724
01:47:23.720 --> 01:47:24.270
Boardroom: Turn off.

725
01:47:24.270 --> 01:47:25.320
Leila: We're calling on you.

726
01:47:25.320 --> 01:47:32.750
Boardroom: Layla, can you turn off the volume on your stream that you're watching, please? Because it's echoing.

727
01:47:32.750 --> 01:47:33.110
Leila: Dude.

728
01:47:33.110 --> 01:47:33.910
Boardroom: for you.

729
01:47:33.910 --> 01:47:38.960
Leila: Next is Layla. Okay, you're asking me to do what?

730

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01:47:39.370 --> 01:47:44.830
Boardroom: To mute the stream that you're listening to? Because we can't hear you.

731
01:47:45.980 --> 01:47:54.009
Leila: You are on track for a 25% increase in property taxes for the average home employee.

732
01:47:54.010 --> 01:47:58.300
Boardroom: We're gonna come back to you. We'll come right back to you, but… Hello? Oh.

733
01:48:02.990 --> 01:48:05.440
Boardroom: Okay.

734
01:48:06.170 --> 01:48:10.800
Boardroom: Let's go to Greg. Greg, you should be able to unmute.

735
01:48:11.890 --> 01:48:16.999
Greg Ferrel: Hey, how are ya? I just wanted to touch on…

736
01:48:20.300 --> 01:48:24.760
Boardroom: Alright, let's go to the caller with a number ending in 211.

737
01:48:31.250 --> 01:48:33.439
Boardroom: You should be able to unmute.

738
01:48:39.270 --> 01:48:45.410
1510****211: I, as a 60-year-old, President of the City of Berkeley, I miss all of the movie theaters.

739
01:48:45.670 --> 01:48:46.769
1510****211: All of them gone.

740
01:48:46.960 --> 01:48:48.910
1510****211: United Artist on Shattuck.

741
01:48:49.030 --> 01:48:51.000
1510****211: California theater in Catridge.

742

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01:48:51.240 --> 01:48:57.789
1510****211: Box theater in Solano, we need to get them back. We need to get some movie theater back. People get addicted to TV.

743
01:48:57.910 --> 01:48:58.830
1510****211: Second.

744
01:48:59.130 --> 01:49:11.189
1510****211: with the heat going through, as a physicist, we're in for a really, really bad time. I think human civilization would last much longer than the end of this century, even if that. The last thing I'd like to mention.

745
01:49:11.370 --> 01:49:15.379
1510****211: that monstrosity in the White House.

746
01:49:15.680 --> 01:49:18.280
1510****211: We have to… we may not even have the election.

747
01:49:18.550 --> 01:49:21.409
1510****211: This man have done everything possible.

748
01:49:21.650 --> 01:49:23.050
1510****211: Again, it's the law.

749
01:49:23.310 --> 01:49:25.670
1510****211: Of the country, against international laws.

750
01:49:25.670 --> 01:49:27.410
Boardroom: I'm sorry to interrupt you.

751
01:49:27.410 --> 01:49:27.760
1510****211: Stand up.

752
01:49:28.310 --> 01:49:28.990
Boardroom: Okay.

753
01:49:29.150 --> 01:49:30.509
Boardroom: Just gonna let you finish.

754

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01:49:33.180 --> 01:49:50.260
Boardroom: Okay, thanks, thanks for your comment. Just a reminder for folks who are online, we're, we're taking comments right now on, the report that we had for our special meeting, which is the, item, it was only one item, which is the presentation and discussion of community survey results.

755
01:49:52.620 --> 01:49:59.380
Boardroom: Okay, next speaker… is, yarrow?

756
01:50:14.990 --> 01:50:23.499
Boardroom: Public comment is not usually like this. For those of you who have not been to a meeting, it's never like this, so I don't know what's happening. Next is Morton.

757
01:50:26.990 --> 01:50:29.890
Morton Wetherspoon: Yes? Yes, hello! Can you hear me?

758
01:50:31.710 --> 01:50:35.659
Boardroom: Yes, we can hear you. Next, we'll go back to Layla.

759
01:50:38.970 --> 01:50:40.459
Boardroom: Oh, where'd my old go?

760
01:50:41.880 --> 01:50:42.810
Boardroom: Okay…

761
01:50:46.510 --> 01:50:48.529
Leila: Okay. Can you hear me?

762
01:50:48.530 --> 01:50:49.260
Boardroom: Yes.

763
01:50:49.260 --> 01:51:07.390
Leila: Good evening, I'm Leela Moncharge, I'm the president of Baja, and I have, baja's told you so much about the architecture that I'm going to tell you something a little different for tonight. I want you to know that I grew up in Berkeley. I came here in 1951, right after the war.

764
01:51:07.780 --> 01:51:16.370
Leila: You know, I want you to really understand that our parents and our teachers took us into City Hall, and they did it often.

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765
01:51:16.470 --> 01:51:27.620
Leila: And part of the reason was they wanted us to understand how important government was, and how important democracy was. And it was… it was always very impressive, because the building was so impressive.

766
01:51:27.760 --> 01:51:39.469
Leila: We learned a lot about what government means in those days. Doesn't mean meeting in a cafeteria, doesn't mean meeting someplace that's gonna change or be different from time to time.

767
01:51:39.470 --> 01:51:44.109
Boardroom: It means being in a place that's in the center of a city and is really impressive.

768
01:51:44.260 --> 01:51:52.310
Leila: And that building was built to be very impressive. So, you know, there's some messaging here. I urge you, and Baja urges.

769
01:51:52.310 --> 01:51:53.610
Boardroom: Thanks, Leela.

770
01:51:53.610 --> 01:51:54.510
Leila: Thank you.

771
01:51:54.510 --> 01:51:55.629
Boardroom: Thank you so much.

772
01:51:56.270 --> 01:51:58.649
Boardroom: Okay, that's all the speakers.

773
01:51:59.060 --> 01:51:59.910
Boardroom: What happened?

774
01:52:00.970 --> 01:52:10.770
Boardroom: Okay, great, thank you so much. Okay, thanks, everyone. Can we go to, comments now from Council… my council colleagues? Do you have any comments?

775
01:52:16.350 --> 01:52:33.430

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Boardroom: Madam Mayor… Okay, go ahead, yep, Councilmember Kisarwani. Thank you very much, Madam Mayor, and, thank you, Mr. White, for the presentation, and, Mr. Merman for your presentation as well. Did somebody with… actually, is Mr. Merman still with us, or no? He's here.

776
01:52:34.160 --> 01:52:35.620
Boardroom: Oh, he is on the Zoom.

777
01:52:36.780 --> 01:52:52.089
Boardroom: Okay, Mr. Merman, just given some of the comments that we heard, can you just explain why the poll of sampling 500 people is representative, and how that works statistically?

778
01:52:54.270 --> 01:52:59.240
David Mermin: Yeah, that's a valid question, and it does… it's counterintuitive.

779
01:52:59.650 --> 01:53:04.669
David Mermin: Who think that, 500 people can represent many thousands of people.

780
01:53:05.130 --> 01:53:13.199
David Mermin: But that is, in fact, how sampling works, and statistics works, and in fact, all of the survey research that's done in the country, most of them

781
01:53:13.410 --> 01:53:19.879
David Mermin: Are done with samples of several hundred, occasionally 1,000 or 2,000 for large national projects.

782
01:53:20.030 --> 01:53:24.670
David Mermin: But for a city the size of Berkeley, a very typical survey,

783
01:53:24.870 --> 01:53:31.110
David Mermin: A sample size would be 500, because that provides… statistically, assuming you

784
01:53:31.310 --> 01:53:36.919
David Mermin: Do it accurately, and that's a very important point, is that it does require expertise to sample

785
01:53:36.970 --> 01:53:53.790

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David Mermin: Representatively and accurately, but if we do so with a random sample of the likely voter universe, it is statistically true that, with a 95% certainty, that the true result, if you interviewed every voter in Berkeley, is within 4.4%.

786
01:53:53.910 --> 01:54:01.839
David Mermin: of the result we got on this survey. Now, there are other sources of error besides the sample size, and we work very hard to control that, so…

787
01:54:02.000 --> 01:54:09.039
David Mermin: It is never a certainty, but this is, the most, efficient.

788
01:54:09.290 --> 01:54:15.529
David Mermin: Cost-effective way to obtain a representative universe of likely voters

789
01:54:16.100 --> 01:54:32.359
David Mermin: to assess the, assess the level of support, across the entire universe of likely voters in the City of Berkeley, and that is a… it's a very reasonable sample size, and everyone who does this work in this field of survey research would

790
01:54:33.050 --> 01:54:36.659
David Mermin: Would… would recognize this as a legitimate sample size.

791
01:54:37.500 --> 01:54:40.990
Boardroom: Okay, thank you very much. And then, Mr. Budenhagen, to the…

792
01:54:40.990 --> 01:54:58.439
Boardroom: point that was raised by former Mayor Bates about an additional survey, I think you already spoke to this during the Q&A, and I actually didn't intend to ask this many questions, because I know this is the comment time, but I think it helps to further the discussion. I just wanted to ask…

793
01:54:58.610 --> 01:55:16.680
Boardroom: I know that we're… you're… we're going to do additional polling. Will you be able to… can you speak to what we will poll on, further at this point? Sure, thank you for the question, Councilmember. The… the… so the follow-up poll, one of the things we want to do, we did not…

794

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01:55:16.750 --> 01:55:26.440
Boardroom: test against potential other ballot measures that people would be seeing on their ballots. So… and I think, David Merman talked a little bit about this, but we do want to…

795
01:55:26.690 --> 01:55:49.240
Boardroom: try to get a sense of how people would view these two issues in light of seeing a regional sales tax measure, or whatever the measures we think might be likely to be on the ballot. So that's, like, one big reason why we want to do it. And then also to kind of refine the language and understand better what people really care about, so that we can come back to you

796
01:55:49.240 --> 01:55:51.590
Boardroom: With these second poll results.

797
01:55:52.190 --> 01:55:59.350
Boardroom: And then really hone in on what we want to come forward with, both from the perspective of ballot language and projects.

798
01:55:59.530 --> 01:56:00.890
Boardroom: Okay.

799
01:56:01.860 --> 01:56:13.439
Boardroom: Okay, my mic is still on. So, so, and it sounds like it would be too much to get into arguments, right? Because it's hard to do that if we don't exactly know what

800
01:56:13.710 --> 01:56:20.319
Boardroom: what, projects we would be pursuing. So, I think we'll, we'll have to,

801
01:56:20.460 --> 01:56:26.840
Boardroom: see how things progress on that. So, I just wanted to voice my position on this.

802
01:56:27.030 --> 01:56:30.469
Boardroom: In terms of the bond measure.

803
01:56:30.540 --> 01:56:42.300
Boardroom: you know, given the polling that 200 million polls the same as 300 million, I think we should pursue the higher number, and I want to appreciate, Mr. White, your comments about how, the…

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804
01:56:42.350 --> 01:56:55.519
Boardroom: amount per $100,000 of assessed value is roughly in line with where we have been in the past. That chart… we probably have seen it in the past, but I don't know that…

805
01:56:55.870 --> 01:57:15.429
Boardroom: when you reference 19… going back to 1993, that's not in the material for tonight, right? Okay, but I think it's something we've looked at before, and maybe as… I just want to suggest as we continue this conversation, it might be good to bring that table back so that we can continue to remind ourselves and the community where we are with costs, because

806
01:57:15.430 --> 01:57:20.330
Boardroom: I do hear… I think the mayor spoke to the affordability concerns, and…

807
01:57:20.460 --> 01:57:37.739
Boardroom: people, you know, making the very valid and reasonable point that if you did buy your home more recently, your assessed value is much higher than people who bought a long time ago. So I think we do want to, be cognizant of those costs, and…

808
01:57:38.120 --> 01:57:41.230
Boardroom: I also think that if we…

809
01:57:41.440 --> 01:57:46.559
Boardroom: Have bonding capacity that is underutilized.

810
01:57:46.560 --> 01:58:03.120
Boardroom: That we are, doing a disservice to the city, because as we know, we have over a billion dollars of deferred maintenance on infrastructure, and so what I see us hopefully being able to do, if this $300 million bond measure passes, is being able to take a bite out of

811
01:58:03.170 --> 01:58:13.390
Boardroom: some of that aging infrastructure, and so to that point of which projects to pursue, I do think we'd need to be… because, you know, some of us have a memory of…

812
01:58:13.670 --> 01:58:22.650

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Boardroom: prior bond measures that didn't meet the two-thirds threshold. So, I think we do have to keep in mind that we're just right at the cusp there. This could…

813
01:58:22.760 --> 01:58:40.230
Boardroom: it seems like the polling's telling us it could go either way, depending on the nature of the campaign, the nature of the projects that are chosen, and the nature of the arguments that are made for and against, and so I do think we should pay close attention to which projects are polling strongly, because our need is so great.

814
01:58:40.280 --> 01:58:53.549
Boardroom: So I think we should focus on those projects, and it seems like we'll have a… be honing in on that even more. It seems like we have some of that info already, and so… and I did want to speak to, because we did hear in public comment

815
01:58:53.950 --> 01:58:58.840
Boardroom: folks talking about the importance of the Civic Center area, I think we…

816
01:58:59.070 --> 01:59:08.090
Boardroom: I think that's something we can poll on, right, in our next round to get a better sense of that, but I do want to say from the polling that we got, it seems like public buildings

817
01:59:08.240 --> 01:59:14.279
Boardroom: is a better approach than focusing solely on the Civic Center buildings.

818
01:59:14.310 --> 01:59:34.130
Boardroom: And then, you know, if we do get the FEMA loan, or we do get other funding for those Civic Center buildings, hopefully we will… we'll have to figure that out in the ballot language, right, of how we can be flexible, in uses. I also think, you know, given the T… measure T1 infrastructure bond experience.

819
01:59:34.130 --> 01:59:46.259
Boardroom: of construction cost escalation. You know, I don't know if we're gonna have a situation where certain projects have a greater cost escalation than others. I don't know if that's something that happens, but,

820
01:59:46.450 --> 01:59:52.719

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Boardroom: I think we also need to think about a little bit of flexibility in that case as well, for cost overruns.

821
01:59:52.840 --> 02:00:11.469
Boardroom: So, okay, that's the bond measure, and then on the sales tax, you know, I had done the item earlier this year to ask us to poll on this when, it became clear that our budget deficit is, you know, roughly $30 million, and what that means in terms of

822
02:00:11.910 --> 02:00:20.369
Boardroom: the types of cuts we'll have to make, so I am in support of putting that on the ballot, and I was very pleased to see that it's…

823
02:00:20.480 --> 02:00:31.319
Boardroom: looks like it would pass, all things… oh, I didn't realize I was on a timer. Oh, okay, I'm basically wrapped up. So, you know, it looks like that one is in a good position to pass, and I think that would just give us…

824
02:00:31.320 --> 02:00:43.980
Boardroom: we're still gonna have very hard decisions to make. This measure wouldn't even go on the ballot till November. We have to pass a budget by June 30th, so… but it may give us some flexibility moving forward,

825
02:00:44.030 --> 02:00:59.829
Boardroom: to protect, some of our vital services and staff. So, that's all I have. Thank you again for the presentation. I'm glad we're having this conversation early so that we can be in a good position come the summer to draft ballot language.

826
02:01:01.630 --> 02:01:11.680
Boardroom: Thanks, and since we're already talking about this, I would like to make the motion to, approve the recommendation. Second. Thank you.

827
02:01:12.100 --> 02:01:19.209
Boardroom: Okay, so, we have a number of comments. I saw Councilmember Humbert's hand go up, and then Councilmember Blackaby.

828
02:01:21.430 --> 02:01:23.549
Mark Humbert: Thank you, Madam Mayor.

829

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02:01:23.810 --> 02:01:43.550
Mark Humbert: I want to thank everybody who's involved with this whole process. It's a whole lot of work. Paul Budenhagen, Dave White, Scott Ferris, finance department, others who helped develop these lists of projects and cost estimates. I want to thank Dave Merman, Lake Research Partners.

830
02:01:43.660 --> 02:01:48.020
Mark Humbert: And our, fire chief and police chief and their departments for…

831
02:01:48.160 --> 02:01:55.519
Mark Humbert: for, contributing to this. I want to say this report and proposal offer a lot of positive news for the city.

832
02:01:55.660 --> 02:02:15.559
Mark Humbert: I'm happy to hear that perceptions of the city's direction and service levels are moving in the right direction. That's heartening, and at least modestly positive. Overall, of course, we want to get these numbers higher, but it seems like we're on a good trajectory, notwithstanding a very chaotic national and global situation.

833
02:02:15.830 --> 02:02:25.709
Mark Humbert: The numbers for a potential bond measure likewise seem very good. I would be in favor of the 300 rather than the 200, since there's not a statistical

834
02:02:25.890 --> 02:02:27.849
Mark Humbert: Significance as between them.

835
02:02:28.010 --> 02:02:45.379
Mark Humbert: I want to say, I'd like to strongly favor keeping the exact funding amounts open so that we have room to maneuver in terms of just how much goes to various categories of project. Flexibility seems really a cardinal thing.

836
02:02:45.780 --> 02:02:51.439
Mark Humbert: I also want to make sure we're leaving room to maneuver when it comes to geographic equity.

837
02:02:51.540 --> 02:02:56.310
Mark Humbert: I know that my district, District 8, is a high resource area within the city.

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838
02:02:56.530 --> 02:02:59.870
Mark Humbert: That has historically benefited from public investment.

839
02:03:00.010 --> 02:03:10.810
Mark Humbert: But I do think it's important that as we work to ensure that we have a bond measure that residents can support citywide, that we at least have some project-specific funds going to every district.

840
02:03:11.060 --> 02:03:15.499
Mark Humbert: I'd like to make sure we have a high degree of flexibility for that, in that regard.

841
02:03:15.650 --> 02:03:21.150
Mark Humbert: There are no specific projects, I don't think, listed in District 8 or 7.

842
02:03:21.270 --> 02:03:31.349
Mark Humbert: And I'd want to make sure those can be in the mix. I think improvements to Fire Station 3 on Russell, right in the Elmwood, modest improvements to Monkey Island Park.

843
02:03:31.600 --> 02:03:40.640
Mark Humbert: And I think, Councilmember Lunapar may be addressed this, a new pocket park at Dwight and Waring. It would be a modest, investment, I think.

844
02:03:40.830 --> 02:03:44.320
Mark Humbert: I also want to say we,

845
02:03:44.600 --> 02:03:49.659
Mark Humbert: Absolutely need to be more specific in the bond measure about where the funding would go.

846
02:03:51.140 --> 02:04:04.079
Mark Humbert: If we have to be, then we simply set percentage floors for key categories, if that's possible, that the public has indicated are its highest priorities. Then we can… we can assure people that there will be a floor on the amount.

847
02:04:04.080 --> 02:04:14.910

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Mark Humbert: But we'll go to those things. But if the highest priorities turn out to be more expensive, we still have some wiggle room. So, flexibility, I think, is critical within, you know, within limits.

848
02:04:15.010 --> 02:04:28.049
Mark Humbert: Sales tax measure, totally in favor of that. Prepared to move forward with that. And since it's a simpler measure, I think there's even less need for additional polling. So thanks a lot, everybody, for all the good work on this.

849
02:04:29.500 --> 02:04:38.019
Boardroom: Thank you, Councilmember. Councilmember McAbee. Thanks, Madam Mayor. I'll be really brief. I just wanted to thank staff for all your work on this, on the great report.

850
02:04:38.020 --> 02:04:55.659
Boardroom: And thanks to David Merman, who I've worked with in a previous life, and it's good to see you here, and see the work here, and really respect the end product here. I agree with my colleagues, you know, I'm pleasantly surprised by the results. I know we still have

851
02:04:55.910 --> 02:05:03.730
Boardroom: room to go to sort of earn that trust and sort of make sure that we can get this over the finish line, because I think it is important to make these investments.

852
02:05:03.820 --> 02:05:16.709
Boardroom: To that end, you know, I think a common thread, as we're moving forward with the budget and moving forward with this is just continued transparency, continue to be very clear on goals and progress, and just kind of earning that trust.

853
02:05:16.710 --> 02:05:25.789
Boardroom: From people who know that they can trust us to be good stewards with their money, we're making smart investments, and we're getting the returns that we set out. So I just think that ongoing discipline of…

854
02:05:25.920 --> 02:05:29.080
Boardroom: Being clear, setting goals, reporting back.

855
02:05:29.080 --> 02:05:50.770
Boardroom: And showing that progress, is really important. The conversation we had earlier about the, the overall context of the total,

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infrastructure deficit, the total, liability that we owe, and just making sure that we're thinking about how this is tracking towards bringing that down measurably, I am interested in continuing that conversation, because it… concerning if.

856
02:05:50.810 --> 02:06:08.600
Boardroom: we continue to invest, but that number keeps getting bigger. Like, what, you know, how can we kind of curb that? And I want to make sure that we're making an impact on that. And lastly, I'll just say, you know, I do not love the fact that we need to consider increasing the sales tax. I agree with other

857
02:06:08.600 --> 02:06:20.349
Boardroom: public commenters, I mean, it is a… it is among the more regressive things that we can, that we can do. I also realize, kind of, the need, of where we are at, and I understand that there is room.

858
02:06:20.350 --> 02:06:23.630
Boardroom: To move there relative to other jurisdictions. I'll say that's just…

859
02:06:23.700 --> 02:06:30.509
Boardroom: the least favorite of my… of the options. I think investing in infrastructure and a bond, obviously, is…

860
02:06:30.520 --> 02:06:45.710
Boardroom: that is widespread and is born proportionally by people who can afford to bear that, I think is important. But, again, I recognize the need, and I will certainly support, the sales tax, but just wanted to comment on that piece.

861
02:06:45.710 --> 02:06:53.030
Boardroom: But again, thanks to staff, and thank you for bringing this forward. I'm eager to move this ahead. It's really important that we get this right as we head into November. So, thank you.

862
02:06:54.740 --> 02:06:57.270
Boardroom: Thank you very much. Councilmember Traeco.

863
02:06:59.730 --> 02:07:03.689
Boardroom: Thank you so much for this presentation,

864
02:07:04.070 --> 02:07:13.130

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Boardroom: It's, just really… also appreciate all the community members that have come out,

865
02:07:13.450 --> 02:07:31.860
Boardroom: I really, appreciated the opportunity last week to join Vice Mayor Luna Para during our joint D4 and 7 listening session in D8 at the beautiful Willard Community Center.

866
02:07:32.060 --> 02:07:46.739
Boardroom: So, this is all very helpful as we consider which projects to include in a potential bond measure, and I appreciate having a clear and consistent understanding of how priorities are being evaluated across categories.

867
02:07:46.740 --> 02:07:52.140
Boardroom: So that we can confidently make decisions about what rises to the top.

868
02:07:52.330 --> 02:07:58.619
Boardroom: As my colleague, Councilmember O'Keefe pointed out, it's important we look at this bond measure holistically.

869
02:07:58.690 --> 02:08:13.979
Boardroom: Especially as multiple measures may be coming forward, and voters will be evaluating them together. I see a real opportunity here to communicate the full value of these investments, including the opportunity costs of not investing in them.

870
02:08:15.220 --> 02:08:18.390
Boardroom: Investing in our city facilities.

871
02:08:18.510 --> 02:08:28.810
Boardroom: can… and I think will reduce ongoing expenses, like external rentals, and create long-term community and revenue benefits.

872
02:08:29.510 --> 02:08:49.200
Boardroom: I also want to highlight that voters clearly care about, protecting the Bay, including reducing pollution flowing into it and addressing flood risks through storm drain upgrades and green infrastructure, alongside safeguarding critical infrastructure from climate risks, like flooding and wildfires.

873
02:08:49.460 --> 02:08:57.050

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Boardroom: As we shape the bond, it's important that these priorities are reflected in a visible and meaningful way in our project selection.

874
02:08:58.320 --> 02:09:02.330
Boardroom: I strongly support going for the higher bond amount.

875
02:09:02.330 --> 02:09:19.779
Boardroom: Especially given inflation and broader global uncertainty, especially if we could ensure that we are well-positioned for matching grants, which is critical to maximizing these investments. And like, my colleagues,

876
02:09:19.780 --> 02:09:34.250
Boardroom: I, I am a reluctant, yes, but still, very much a yes in support of putting a half-cent sales tax measure, because…

877
02:09:34.420 --> 02:09:42.309
Boardroom: The… The costs of, frankly, not doing so will be…

878
02:09:42.920 --> 02:10:02.410
Boardroom: devastating to the city. And finally, in, you know, as the District 4 representatives, of course, I would be remiss, not to say this. I want to underscore the importance of investing in

879
02:10:02.640 --> 02:10:10.239
Boardroom: Our civic center institutions, which have long been a pillar of our democracy and civic life.

880
02:10:10.650 --> 02:10:15.430
Boardroom: I know that we will not be able to reopen them overnight.

881
02:10:15.570 --> 02:10:20.080
Boardroom: But the costs of continuing to neglect them.

882
02:10:20.360 --> 02:10:34.929
Boardroom: will accumulate, and we cannot afford to have demolition by neglect of these storied institutions. We should also ensure that community priorities, such as green infrastructure and parks.

883
02:10:34.930 --> 02:10:49.870
Boardroom: are clearly reflected in the project mix we are considering. From a strategic standpoint, we need to be mindful that voter support can

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shift between polling and the ballot, and that clarity, trust, and strong communication will be critical.

884
02:10:50.420 --> 02:11:09.240
Boardroom: I was taking copious mental notes when, Tom, former Mayor Bates was speaking, because, he knows how to get ballot measures passed. I don't know if we, have, just the…

885
02:11:09.240 --> 02:11:17.260
Boardroom: The resources and the time available to do multiple, ballot… to do multiple additional surveys.

886
02:11:17.260 --> 02:11:29.709
Boardroom: And that's why what goes on this survey will be crucial. But I have trust, in, the work of this pollster, does a great job.

887
02:11:29.710 --> 02:11:34.970
Boardroom: And overall, this is a strong foundation, and I appreciate the work as we move Towards.

888
02:11:35.240 --> 02:11:50.440
Boardroom: shaping a responsible and compelling, bond measure, as well as, a potential, half-cent sales tax measure increase. Thank you. Vice President Obara.

889
02:11:51.100 --> 02:12:01.819
Boardroom: Thank you. I want to thank staff, for all of their work on this, and the polling team. This is really incredible and valuable work, so thank you.

890
02:12:02.200 --> 02:12:12.899
Boardroom: I've… similarly to my colleagues, I've heard, from community members about the concerns about the progressive nature of a sales tax and a property tax on assessed value.

891
02:12:12.900 --> 02:12:22.250
Boardroom: And I really hear that, and I worry even more about the even more regressive nature of the effects of the long-term budget cuts that we're facing.

892
02:12:23.330 --> 02:12:43.160
Boardroom: So I'll be supporting the staff recommendation. I also wanted to add on to Councilmember Hubbard's comments. I don't want to get too

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much into the specific projects, given the scope of this meeting, but I heard from some constituents, both at our neighborhood group meeting and, separately, the goal of

893
02:12:43.200 --> 02:12:57.730
Boardroom: building a pocket park, or any kind of more permanent infrastructure at the closed slip lane on Dwight and Piedmont. This is a park's poor, very dense neighborhood, and I'd love to see that being added to the list of potential projects funded by the measure. Thank you.

894
02:12:58.060 --> 02:13:00.280
Boardroom: Thank you, Councilmember Taplin.

895
02:13:00.550 --> 02:13:07.009
Boardroom: Thank you very much, Madam Mayor, and thanks to the team, and to my colleagues, and the people who spoke tonight.

896
02:13:07.420 --> 02:13:14.900
Boardroom: I don't have that much to say, I just wanted to say thank you for the presentation and all the work that's gone into this so far.

897
02:13:14.900 --> 02:13:30.229
Boardroom: Councilor Trague's remarks, pretty much captured what I was gonna say. I would just add that as one of the West Berkeley Council members, it's really important to me to keep a sharp focus on the equity priorities, parks.

898
02:13:30.320 --> 02:13:33.320
Boardroom: stormwater projects and the waterfront. Thank you.

899
02:13:33.700 --> 02:13:35.780
Boardroom: Thank you, Councilmember O'Keefe.

900
02:13:38.780 --> 02:13:45.399
Boardroom: Just a couple things, regarding the sales tax measure, I just want to say, I'm…

901
02:13:45.600 --> 02:13:54.399
Boardroom: kind of a psychotic penny-pincher, and I had no idea that our sales tax rate was less than the surrounding cities until this came up.

902
02:13:54.890 --> 02:14:00.949

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Boardroom: And… I appreciate the argument that it's regressive, but at the same time, I…

903
02:14:01.720 --> 02:14:14.849
Boardroom: unless I'm just really out of touch, I… I don't think many people know that, and therefore, I… I think we're kind of have been leaving money on the table, literally, by not having done this sooner. And so I… given…

904
02:14:15.350 --> 02:14:26.620
Boardroom: given that it could potentially plug a third of our structural deficit, I could not be more in favor of the sales tax measure. I just really wanna…

905
02:14:26.760 --> 02:14:33.270
Boardroom: Say that as emphatically as I can. And I appreciate Council, Vice Mayor Lunapara's point that

906
02:14:33.940 --> 02:14:49.930
Boardroom: not funding city services is extremely aggressive. That was a really, really excellent, thing to point out. So, very excited about that. Regarding the bond measure, I don't have anything more to say except just that it's a huge amount of work, and thank you so much to city staff for everything that's gone into this and will continue to go into this.

907
02:14:49.930 --> 02:15:03.229
Boardroom: You guys are doing a great job. Really good… it's a huge amount of money, so the fact that the process is so, carefully thought out and so much time is being spent on it is really, appropriate, and you guys are doing a great job.

908
02:15:03.890 --> 02:15:08.179
Boardroom: And I just want to say, like, it was nice to see that

909
02:15:08.420 --> 02:15:28.230
Boardroom: at least more… majority of people think that the city is going in the right direction. That felt really good. I think that is also indicated in the high level of support. I think people seem really willing to invest their money in the city, and it shows… they have a lot of pride in the city, and they should, because the city is amazing. This is the best place to live.

910
02:15:28.270 --> 02:15:29.940

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Boardroom: And the whole planet Earth.

911
02:15:29.990 --> 02:15:41.799
Boardroom: And, and everybody knows it, and I think these, poll results really, really show that, and I just wanted to highlight that, and just feel good about that, and I, I really, this is very exciting. Good job, everyone.

912
02:15:42.570 --> 02:15:46.710
Boardroom: Thank you, yep, thank you, Councilmember. Councilmember Bartlett.

913
02:15:47.540 --> 02:16:05.940
Boardroom: Thank you, Madam Mayor. I, too, want to just join myself to all the previous comments, and regarding the district equity, you know, the T1 formula was really good, the way that was rolled out. I think it would be good to do that again, I think, to make sure, that the resources are rolled out evenly and fairly.

914
02:16:05.940 --> 02:16:08.169
Boardroom: And equitably.

915
02:16:08.600 --> 02:16:27.150
Boardroom: And, I want to do a good plug for downtown, because it is necessary. I realize the real price tag for downtown, development is much higher than the money we would get from this, but at least gets us on the way. And we do need a really, real vibrant civic Center, square, like other cities.

916
02:16:27.150 --> 02:16:32.130
Boardroom: With a water fountain, too, like a water-based fountain. I see this every time.

917
02:16:32.139 --> 02:16:34.080
Boardroom: And, and then…

918
02:16:34.110 --> 02:16:44.560
Boardroom: And finally, I want to say it's really nice to get the vote of confidence from people. They like the work we're doing, they're supporting us, and they have faith in what we're doing, and it's really wonderful to see. Thank you, Madam Mayor.

919
02:16:45.870 --> 02:16:56.080

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Boardroom: Thank you. Councilmember Taplin, did you want to add something? Yes, thank you very much. I also wanted to put in a plug for Francis Lawreyer, which is really the heart of the Swim Helo Park neighborhood.

920
02:16:56.180 --> 02:17:10.600
Boardroom: not only is it a wonderful community center, it's also meant to serve as an evacuation center in the event of emergency. I think for our city buildings, it's important that we prioritize those that fulfill a range of needs for the community and for the city.

921
02:17:10.770 --> 02:17:26.000
Boardroom: And it was, one of our flagship projects, that had to be, shelved from T1, and it's very important to me to demonstrate the city's ability to finish projects that we promised to undergo. Thank you.

922
02:17:28.150 --> 02:17:52.629
Boardroom: Thank you all. Thanks so much for your comments. I really want to thank the City Manager's Office, so Paul, David, also Carrie, who's our silent partner up here with David, would love to hear you present next time. I know you did a lot of work on this, so thank you very much. And I also know that a lot of grants have been applied for by you, so when we talk about leveraging grant fund… funding for grants.

923
02:17:52.629 --> 02:17:56.150
Boardroom: I just want everyone to know that Carrie does a lot of that work, so…

924
02:17:56.320 --> 02:18:21.310
Boardroom: Big shout out there. Thank you all for putting this presentation together, and just for the heavy lifting of working with the Lake team to put this poll together. I really want to acknowledge how challenging it is to balance all these different priorities, districts, and needs. There's a lot of thought that goes into this, and so thank you. And thank you also to everyone from the city staff who worked on organizing this and facilitating the conversation. So, Scott, Ferris, I know you're here.

925
02:18:21.309 --> 02:18:37.920
Boardroom: but, other folks have been involved with those conversations as well, around the city, around the GO bond. And I also want to thank the community for participating in the community meetings and the survey. I don't know who you are out there who took the survey, but thank you for taking it, and thanks for your confidence.

926

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02:18:37.920 --> 02:19:02.790
Boardroom: And really big shout out to our Realize Vision 2050 Task Force. In the past year, we had many conversations with folks in our city throughout a variety of different specialties, who gave thoughts and inputs, and I really want to let you know that that was very helpful. In terms of projects, I know folks have pet projects that they really care about, and I just also want to encourage all of us

927
02:19:02.790 --> 02:19:27.749
Boardroom: my council colleagues, to remember that these projects benefit everybody in the city. So, you know, when we're supporting something in downtown, or Francis Albreyer, like, we go… our residents go to places throughout the city, so just want to keep us united in our thinking about how this supports Berkeley as a whole. And also, just to second, what some folks have also mentioned about making sure we really want to have strong accountability in here.

928
02:19:27.750 --> 02:19:34.009
Boardroom: I love to… to… I love that that's something I know we're already talking about.

929
02:19:34.219 --> 02:19:43.560
Boardroom: So, in my office, we really value community engagement, also, and encouraging folks to engage with local government. Infrastructure is…

930
02:19:43.709 --> 02:19:58.690
Boardroom: really the backbone of our city. If we have, like I like to say, 100-year-old infrastructure, basically, and with over $1.5 billion of deferred needs, it's… you can see the need versus what we have. There's a big difference.

931
02:19:58.760 --> 02:20:13.989
Boardroom: So this bond is really needed to ensure that our infrastructure is maintained, and also that we're prepared for the future. We talk a lot about climate change here in this city, and this is our way that we're really preparing for it. So we really need our community to come together to help fund these projects.

932
02:20:14.090 --> 02:20:31.430
Boardroom: For every year that we don't adequately invest in our infrastructure, the deferred costs increase exponentially, and I think that's an important part. I want folks to know about that. This $300 million will allow us to leverage additional grant opportunities, as I mentioned, and…

933

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02:20:32.000 --> 02:20:40.869
Boardroom: Also, I want to mention a couple of things that I wanted to pull out. So, given that Berkeley is the birthplace.

934
02:20:40.870 --> 02:21:05.580
Boardroom: of the disability rights movement. I'd like to make sure that accessibility is incorporated throughout our projects, and just generally want to second what Berkeley voters… Berkeley residents are saying about… about, accessibility being important. I was pleased to see that over 70% of the folks polled understand the need to support infrastructure generally. One of my favorite things about being there is getting to learn about all of the different projects that are

935
02:21:05.580 --> 02:21:30.330
Boardroom: happening in the city. I've gotten many tours from Public Works and our Parks Department, and also, you know, done ride-alongs with police and fire and a sit-along with dispatch. And, that's really allowed me to see the amazing things that are happening throughout our city, and so I really want to make sure folks understand how much work is happening all around us that you may not notice, day-to-day as you're going about your

936
02:21:30.330 --> 02:21:36.480
Boardroom: about your business, but I get a chance to see that specifically, and it's an incredible honor.

937
02:21:36.510 --> 02:22:01.240
Boardroom: there's always room for improvement, but I'm very glad to see that the confidence from the community is strong in us, in our direction. 56% of folks polled says they think that Berkeley is heading in the right direction, and I really want to thank my council colleagues, because I think that us working together through really challenging situations in a civil and respectful way, is really reflected by these numbers. So, thank you all so much for

938
02:22:01.240 --> 02:22:21.059
Boardroom: for the work that you're doing to show our residents what a highly, you know, functioning, you know, progressive city can look like. So, thank you, very much, and thank you so much for the presentation this evening. So, I know we have a motion on the floor. I will ask that we please take the roll. Okay, on the motion to approve the…

939
02:22:21.060 --> 02:22:31.289
Boardroom: recommendation to direct the City Manager to prepare draft ballot language and authorize a second community survey. Councilmember Kesslerwein? Yes.

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940
02:22:31.430 --> 02:22:40.200
Boardroom: Taplin? Yes. Bartlett? Yes. Trega? Aye. O'Keefe? Yes. Blackaby? Yes. Lunapara? Yes. Humbert?

941
02:22:40.380 --> 02:22:41.240
Mark Humbert: Yes.

942
02:22:41.470 --> 02:22:50.899
Boardroom: And Mary Ishii. Yes. Okay, motion carries. Okay, thank you all so much. Really grateful. Okay, so we have…

943
02:22:50.990 --> 02:22:57.689
Boardroom: finished our one item on the meeting, so I will entertain a motion to adjourn. So moved.

944
02:22:57.740 --> 02:23:15.389
Boardroom: Okay, a second. And do we need to take the roll again? Yeah, because we have someone online. Can we take the roll again on this, please? Okay. To adjourn, Councilmember Kesarwani? Yes. Taplin? Yes. Bartlett? Yes. Tragum? Aye. O'Keefe? Yes. Blackaby? Yes. Lunapara? Yes. Humbert?

945
02:23:15.390 --> 02:23:16.250
Mark Humbert: Yes.

946
02:23:16.250 --> 02:23:22.580
Boardroom: And Mayor Ishii. Yes. Okay, we're… Alright, meeting is adjourned. Thanks, everyone.

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